

Ya Diktu: Grammar of the Minoan Peak Sanctuary Libation Formula

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“Just as Australia’s aborigines ‘dream’ their landscape through song lines and the Japanese imbue their mountains with the ancestral spirits of the kamae, so the Minoans created peak sanctuaries, cave sanctuaries, spring sanctuaries, and all the other rural sanctuaries we strive to recognize.”

— Peatfield, *“The Topography of Minoan Peak Sanctuaries Revisited”* (2009), 253

§1. Prolegomena

In the popular imagination, Minoan Crete is the land of labyrinths and bull leapers. While this caricature veers toward the simplistic, it owes much to the testimony of ancient Greek and Roman commentators. Homer famously invokes Crete as the land of “ninety cities, / language mixing with language side by side,” ruled over by King Minos, who “each ninth year / conferred with almighty Zeus himself” (*Od.* 19.172–179). Down the centuries, the dynasty of Minos became the fixation of Athenian playwrights like Euripides, historians such as Herodotos and Diodorus Siculus, and the poets Virgil and Catullus. Despite attempts by Plato and Plutarch to bring historicity to the myths, Minoan civilization found itself bound to the name of a single man.

What modern historians classify as properly ‘Minoan’ emerged sometime in the 3rd millennium BCE, evidenced by the pottery, gem engravings, and material culture that distinguish it from, for example, the Cycladic. It may be the mingling of the Cycladic and the Cretan in the Early Minoan I (~3100 BCE) at Hagia Photia that planted those seeds which would later bloom into the ill-fated island city of Thera.¹ By the Protopalatial period (~1925 BCE), the first stirrings of centralization appeared at Knossos, heralded further by the unveiling of the Cretan hieroglyphic system. Over the next century, hieroglyphs gave rise to the syllabary that we call Linear A, overlapping briefly with them. The transition to Linear A coincided not only with the construction of the first “palaces” of Knossos, but also the ritualization of the peak sanctuary at Mt. Iouktas.

§2. The Cult of the Mountaintop

The archaeological site of Knossos has been excavated since 1878, first by Minos Kalokairinos, and then by Arthur C. Evans in 1900. Evans followed this with Mt. Iouktas in 1909 (*PM* I, 153–159; see also Karetsou 1981, 137), establishing a precedent which led to the discovery of an entire range of mountaintop shrines across the expanse of Crete. As Alan

¹The cemetery at Hagia Photia, with 263 tombs of Cycladic design, is widely regarded as the earliest known Cycladic colony on Cretan soil (Betancourt 2003, 3–4; Davaras & Betancourt 2004, 7).

Peatfield (1983) relayed in “The Topography of Minoan Peak Sanctuaries,” these sites likely served two functions at their onset: to secure divine protection for herds of domestic goats and sheep, and to interconnect towns and villages through religious tradition. Peatfield further noted, “The link between peak sanctuary cult and pastoral farming is also strongly demonstrated by the vast numbers of votive clay figurines of domestic farm animals” (Peatfield 1983, 273). Reinforcing this association all the more, a stone rhyton from Zakros depicts Cretan wild goats gathered around a tripartite shrine with altars, horns of consecration, and a temenos wall (Militello 2020, 90, 96). Although the greatest density of shrines was uncovered in the vicinity of Siteia on the eastern shore, archaeologists agree that Mt. Iouktas overlooking Knossos was the grandest of them all.

At Mt. Iouktas, it is possible to reconstruct the institutionalization of the peak sanctuary cult as it moved from the sphere of shepherds in Middle Minoan I (~2100–1875 BCE) to that of priestesses in Middle Minoan III (~1750–1700 BCE), and priests in Late Minoan II (~1470–1420 BCE). A trove of artifacts, encompassing stone, gold, bronze, lead, clay, and even murex shells, speaks to the prominence of Iouktas in Minoan society and the degree to which it was idealized across the island (Karetsou & Koehl 2013, 135–143; Karetsou & Koehl 2012, 207–221). In its layout, the sanctuary site included a formidable stepped altar surrounded by smaller libation tables, rows of descending rooms, a natural sinkhole (Karetsou, Kanta & Spiliotopoulou 2023, 384–385), and a Minoan road which led directly to Knossos. Its accessibility to pilgrims and worshipers saw its continued usage well into the Iron Age, explaining why a local shepherd believed in 1834 that Iouktas was in fact the “tomb of Zeus” (Pashley 1837, 1:211–12). Today a vestige of this cult survives in mountain chapel festivals to Aphenidis Christos where “many people from all over the district gather to make the pilgrimage up the mountain” (Peatfield 1983, 275; cf. Peatfield & Morris 2012, 233).

Amidst the unearthing of artifacts at Iouktas, archaeologists recognized the distinctive markings of Linear A upon stone libation tables, clay vessels, and an alabaster cup. Without attempting to interpret the language, Kyriakidis observed that “these inscriptions, though on different types of vessels and from different periods (OP and NP) or places, seem to consistently belong to the same two formulae” (Kyriakidis 2002b, 125). Of all the inscriptions found at Iouktas, IOZa2 is the most complete example of one such libation formula, engraved on a fragmentary serpentine stone libation table found in the vicinity of its altar.² Recent scholarship asserts the formula to be “the richest source of information about the grammar of the language(s) of Linear A” (Thomas 2020, 1). It is IOZa2 which proves to be the most intelligible inscription in the entire Linear A corpus.

§3. The Corpus

If a proverbial holy grail exists within the Classics today, it is the decipherment of Linear A, and the identification of its language family. Of course, like any scholarly quest, this one has been contentious from the start. Since the publication of *Documents in Mycenaean Greek* in 1956, countless attempts have been made, suggesting Semitic, Luwian, Hurrian,

²IOZa2 (Iouktas) is catalogued as “Serpentine stone” by the Herakleion Archaeological Museum (inv. L 3557; INSCRIBE 3D model). Serpentine tables are also attested at Syme and Kophinas (Kyriakidis 2002b, 118). Davis (2014) provides the definitive lithological survey of all inscribed stone vessels.

Greek, and Etruscan readings of Linear A inscriptions. I myself waded into these waters by way of the collected works of Jane E. Harrison, and subsequently Cyrus H. Gordon's *Evidence for the Minoan Language*. Having been thoroughly obsessed with the Greeks and Romans in my adolescence, I found in adulthood a kinship with the underdogs of antiquity—namely, the Phoenicians, and my familial namesake, the Minoans.³ With Gordon's scholarship (and that of his successors) before me, I felt compelled to continue on the Semitic path.

When Gordon (1966a) published *Evidence for the Minoan Language*, he had at his disposal no more than 150–300 transcribed inscriptions, only one of which belonged to Iouktas. Initially, he saw in Linear A terminology that pointed to an East Semitic classification, *ku-ni-su* being one such example (“emmer wheat”; cf. Akkadian *kunāšu*). After obtaining Brice's 1961 corpus, Gordon encountered West Semitic terms such as *ya-ne* (“wine”; cf. Hebrew יַיִן *yayin*; Ugaritic *yn*), which persuaded him to reclassify Minoan as West Semitic (Rendsburg 1996). Classicists such as Chadwick were quick to dismiss Gordon's findings, preferring to omit any mention of them rather than engage with the hypothesis (Bernal 1987, 419). Semiticists who did engage with Gordon's work took issue with the language's tendency to exhibit Canaanite, Aramaic, and Akkadian behaviors, seemingly to suit one translation at a time. Although scholars like David I. Owen had observed this intra-Semitic fluidity in Eblaite (Rendsburg 1996, 41), most of academia moved on.⁴

As of September 2026, through the efforts of intrepid archaeologists, orthographers, and linguists, the Linear A corpus has grown to 1,780 individual inscriptions, with an estimated five more awaiting inclusion from RILA-S1 (Del Frio & Zurbach 2025), pending digitization. In the past, the corpus has traditionally been counted at around 1,400 entries. I have reconciled and deduplicated all 1,468 documents from the five volumes of GORILA (Godart & Olivier 1976–1985), 261 additional entries tabulated by George Douros from post-1985 publications (Hallager 1996), as well as 51 face-level records from the SigLA database (Salgarella & Castellan 2021). Some may contest the value of Douros's numbered nodule faces; but I treated every datum of Linear A as significant in my decipherment of the underlying language. I would also be remiss not to mention the digitized corpus known as lineara.xyz (Hogan 2019–) which laid the groundwork for my exploration and annotation of its inscriptions.

Before proceeding, I must reiterate how Linear A inscriptions have been read. Given that Linear A preceded and coexisted with Linear B for ~50–90 years (Salgarella & Petrakis 2026, Table 1), scholars stretching back to Ventris have long assumed that Linear B sound values could be applied to their Linear A counterparts. Steele & Meißner (2017, 110) concluded that “the backward projection of sound values from Linear B to Linear A must

³The surname *di Mino* traces to Sciacca in Agrigento province, southwestern Sicily, 20 km west of ancient Heraclea Minoa (Capo Bianco), a colony named for King Minos (Diodorus IV.79). It sits on the Semitic $\sqrt{m-n-y}$ root (*mānā* “to allot, apportion”; Akkadian *manū* “to count, assign”), which connects Minos, the pre-Islamic goddess Manāt, and Hebrew *Mānī* (Isaiah 65:11) through a shared semantic field of divine portioning.

⁴Gordon's students continued the work: Astour (*Hellenosemitica*, 1965a) deconstructed the Greek mythological cycles from Kadmos to Europa, exposing Canaanite narratives, divine names, and cult practices; Stieglitz (1971a, 1971b) showed that Minoan vessel names and accounting conventions parallel biblical formulas; Rendsburg (1996) defended the methodology and showed structural parallels between HT 88 and Joshua 12:1–24, considered the significance of Linear A inscriptions excavated at Lachish and Tel Haror in Israel (Rendsburg 1998), and developed a systematic framework for identifying regional variation in Biblical Hebrew (*Israeli Hebrew in the Book of Kings*, 2002).

be regarded as legitimate.” Dr. Salgarella, the foremost palaeographer of Linear A and a co-creator of SigLA, has endorsed such views, while cautioning, “our justifiable assumption of the existence of connections between Linear A and Linear B orthography clashes with our ignorance of the details of this connection” (Salgarella & Petrakis 2026, §Intro). She emphasizes that Linear A has resisted decipherment precisely because the vast majority of its inscriptions dwell in the realm of administrative records. Recent attempts to extract linguistic structure from the corpus, using the latest typological diagnostics, have also fallen short for reasons discussed below (Davis 2026). Consequently, Minoan is often described as a language isolate.⁵

Studying the methods of Cyrus H. Gordon, Alice Kober, and Michael Ventris, I identified a set of inscriptions that repeat a recognizable sequence of syllables and words. The sequence itself occurs at least 15 times across 7 sites, showing minor variations which may be explained by dialect, verbal morphology, and the resident deity in question. At Iouktas, the mountain peak shrine par excellence, this formula manifests in the form of IOZa2. By deconstructing this inscription, word by word, we now have the means to fully decipher and translate what I contend is the most coherent liturgical prayer in all of Bronze Age Crete.⁶ Grammatically, IOZa2 may be divided into three parts: invocation, presentation, and reception.

§4. The Formula

IOZa2 (Iouktas): A-TA-I-^{*}301-WA-JA · JA-DI-KI-TU · JA-SA-SA-RA-ME · U-NA-KA-NA-SI · I-PI-NA-MA · SI-RU-TE · TA-NA-RA-TE-U-TI-NU · I

§4.1. Position 1: The Invocation Verb

Sign	AB Number	Linear B	Value	Morphological Function
A	AB08	B 08 𐀀	/ʾa/	1cs person prefix (“I”)
TA	AB59	B 59 𐀓	/ta/	tG middle-reflexive stem morpheme
I	AB28	B 28 𐀛	/i/	Stem vowel (invariant across 15 attestations)
301	—	(none)	/na/	Root C ₁ of √n-w-y “to dwell” (proposed)
WA	AB54	B 54 𐀖	/wa/	Root C ₂

⁵See Salgarella 2022; Nepal and Perono Cacciafoco 2024; Davis 2026, 45, 48, 50.

⁶By contrast, the roughly 6,000 surviving Linear B inscriptions—more than three times the present Linear A corpus—yield no prayers. The only remotely liturgical text is PY Tn 316, a third-person administrative record of a ceremony: *i-je-to-qe pa-ki-ja-si do-ra-qe pe-re po-re-na-qe a-ke, po-ti-ni-ja AUR ^{*}215VAS 1 MUL 1*, “At Pylos, he sacrifices at Pa-ki-ja-ne, brings gifts, and leads the *po-re-na*. For the Mistress: one gold cup and one woman” (LiBER, PY Tn 316).

Sign	AB Number	Linear B	Value	Morphological Function
JA	AB57	B 57 𐀑	/ya/	Root C ₃

At position 1, A-TA-I-*301-WA-JA is as perplexing as any word within the Linear A corpus, aided in no small part by the unknown sign embedded at its center. Looking past *301 for a moment, however, we can discern the hallmarks of a Semitic verbal conjugation.

The opening A- is a first-person prefix common to all Semitic languages, followed by a tG stem morpheme (-TA-) that signifies the middle-reflexive sense. When rendered into English, this derived stem conveys that the subject acts upon herself. Minoan's close cousins, Akkadian and Ugaritic, both infix this -t- morpheme after the first root consonant (e.g., Akkadian *iptaras* "he decided" from $\sqrt{p-r-s}$; Ugaritic *tmthš* "they fought each other" from $\sqrt{m-ḥ-š}$, KTU 1.6 vi). Conversely, Biblical Hebrew and Ge'ez preserve prefixed tG formations, whereas Arabic and Byblian Phoenician exhibit the metathesized Gt pattern (Hutton & Marzouk 2012, 12–14).⁷ What this implies about the East–West Semitic divide will be discussed further on.

To move past the obstacle that is *301, we must challenge underlying assumptions about Linear A. The first: it is indeed possible to encounter two signs that represent the same phonetic value. The standard /na/ syllabogram already exists in the script as NA (AB06), which appears throughout this very inscription at positions 4, 5, and 7. *301 is an allograph of NA: a second sign writing /na/, but one that carries symbolic and semantic weight. In 238 of its 291 attestations—predominantly on Hagia Triada nodules, with additional examples at Khania, Knossos, and Zakros—*301 stands alone as a logographic abbreviation, plausibly for *nawā* "dwelling, temple" itself.⁸ The root *nawā* (Akkadian *nawūm* "steppeland; area around a town"; Huehnergard 2011) may also be compared with Mycenaean *na-wi-jo*, "of the temple" (PY Jn 829), and Classical *ναός* "temple."⁹

In the formula, *301 functions syllabically as /na/, the first root consonant of $\sqrt{n-w-y}$. Its selection over ordinary /na/ or AB06 may reflect the sanctity of the sign itself, or a standardized scribal convention. I deduced this by querying a database of Semitic roots, searching for three consonant systems containing *waw* and *yod* as their second and third consonants, respectively. The sound I proposed needed to complete this verbal form, and fit into every other occurrence of *301 within the Linear A corpus. Under these strict conditions, only /na/ stood its ground.¹⁰

⁷The exact morpheme boundary between the stem marker and the root cannot be determined from the syllabic spelling alone. The tG morpheme in this language has been vocalized as *-ta-* rather than bare *-t-*, with the I sign representing an invariant stem vowel across all 15 attestations of this verb.

⁸Signs functioning both syllabically and logographically are not uncommon across ancient scripts. Bennett (1972, 63) documents syllabic signs used as ideograms or as adjuncts to ideograms—single syllabograms abbreviating full words, normally by their first syllable—and Palaima (2005, 269, 272–274) discusses the broader "double writing" convention in Mycenaean administrative practice. In cuneiform, signs are routinely polyvalent.

⁹Professor Gary Rendsburg reminded me of this connection when we first met to discuss Linear A. He had endorsed the same etymology in his defense of Bernal's *Black Athena*. See Rendsburg (1989, 77–78).

¹⁰Other NWS roots of the -w-y pattern exist—notably $\sqrt{d-w-y}$ "to be ill" (Ugaritic *dwy*, Hebrew דָּוָה)—but none produce a contextually viable reading at this position. The same sign produces three independent Semitic readings elsewhere in the corpus: *301-SI = *nāšī* "prince" ($\sqrt{n-š-}$, TIZb1), TE-*301 = *tēna* "fig" ($\sqrt{t-ṣ-n}$, HT8a), and NA-TU-*301-NE = *natūnān* "the dedicated one" ($\sqrt{n-t-n}$, SKOZc1).

By translating this single word, we begin to understand the nature of Minoan art and what its iconography has portrayed all along. Tully and Crooks suggested that “in the apparent absence of cult images, envisioned and enacted epiphany are thought to be the ways in which the Minoans interacted with the divine in ritual” (2015, 139). While the Greek myths offer no shortage of ecstatic prophecies, the meaning of A-TA-I-NA-WA-JA is sharpened by examining Hebrew **הַתְּנַבֵּא** *hitnabbē*, represented in 1 Sam 10:6 by **וְהַתְּנַבֵּיתָ** *wəhitnabbîṭā*. After anointing him as king of Israel, Samuel tells Saul how the *ruach* of the Lord will “rush upon him” and he will “make himself a prophet” with them (author’s translation). The prophet or prophetess who makes themselves a vessel is “spoken through by the will of an ancestor, deity, or spirit” (Keller 2002, 101).

Read as A-TA-I-NA-WA-JA, /’atainawayā/, the first word of this prayer is an act of self-consecration: “I make myself a dwelling.”

Biblical Parallels: Jeremiah 31:23; Exodus 15:13

יְבָרְכֶךָ יְהוָה הַהֹר־שֶׁדֶק

“May YHWH bless you, **nēwēh-šedeq**, holy mountain.” (author’s translation; text: BHS, p. 1150)

נָחִיתָ בְּחִסְדְּךָ עִם זֶה גְּאֻלָּתָהּ נְהִלְתָּ בְּעֹזְךָ אֶל הַהֹר־שֶׁדֶק

“You led in Your love the people whom You redeemed; in Your strength You guided them to Your holy **nēwēh**.” (author’s translation; text: BHS, p. 173)

§4.2. Position 2: The Sacred Mountain

Sign	AB Number	Linear B	Value	Morphological Function
JA	AB57	B 57 𐀑	/ya/	Vocative particle (“O!”)
DI	AB07	B 07 𐀓	/di/	Root C ₁ of √d-q-q
KI	AB67	B 67 𐀓	/ki/	Root C ₂
TU	AB69	B 69 𐀓	/tu/	Feminine nominal ending

In position 2, JA-DI-KI-TU completes the invocation started with A-TA-I-NA-WA-JA, naming the sanctuary deity herself. She is no less than the personification of the mountain, preserved in Mycenaean as *di-ka-ta-jo* (Δικταῖος, “Diktaean”; KN Fp 1+31) and Classical Greek as Δικτή. During the Neopalatial period to which *Diqqitu* belongs, she was the mother, the goddess, and the mountain all at once. Goettner-Abendroth states it plainly: “In matriarchy, divinity is immanent, for the whole world is regarded as divine—as feminine divine. This is evident ... Mother Earth who brings forth everything living” (Cichon 2022, 237, quoting Goettner-Abendroth 2007, 6). To deny this truth about the Minoans in their Early and Middle periods is to ignore that in Minoan art, “women appear as priestesses, votaries, adorants, or attendants of the Goddess, or as the divinity herself” (Cichon 2022, 183). By the Late Minoan, a crisis of faith was well underway, coinciding with the arrival of Mycenaeans from the mainland.¹¹

¹¹The eruption of Thera c. 1628–1600 BCE—one of the largest natural disasters ever witnessed in human history (VEI 7; Şahoğlu et al. 2022; Riley 2004, 4)—destabilized the entire eastern Mediterranean, brought a decade of famine to eastern Crete, and opened the door to Mycenaean takeover at Knossos.

Heading this position, JA or *ya* functions as a vocative particle, much as it does in modern Arabic *يا الله* (*yā Allāh*) or Ugaritic *yā Baʿlu* (KTU 1.119:28'). Astour's "Some New Divine Names from Ugarit" connects DI-KI-TU to *dqt* in Ugarit itself. The root √d-q-q means "to be small, fine"; *dqt* denotes a "small (female) animal"—ewe or she-goat—preserved in Rabbinic Hebrew as *בהמה דקה* "small cattle" (m. Bava Qamma 7:7).¹² Moreover, a theonym *Diqatu* appears in a Ugaritic list of gods (KTU 1.102:8; = RS 24.246), which was likely vocalized *daqqatu* or *diqqatu* (Astour 1966b). On the subject of the Diktaean cave, the poet Hesiod provides us with an etymology: he calls the mountain *Αἰγαίω ἐν ὄρει*, "Goat's Mountain" (*Theogony* 484), a "Greco-Semitic onomastic doublet" in Astour's own words (1966b, 284).

Read as /yā Diqqitu/, the Goddess *Diqqitu* is invited to dwell within the priestess and those gathered who chant her name.

Ugaritic Parallel: KTU 1.119 (RS 24.266, lines 26'–36')

(28') y b'lm ... (33') qdš b'l n'l · ntbt b[...] (34') ntlk

"O Ba'lu, ... To the sanctuary, O Ba'lu, we shall ascend; that path, O Ba'lu, we shall take."
(Pardee 2002, 150)

Qur'anic Parallel: Sura Saba 34:10

يَا جِبَالُ أَوِّبِي مَعَهُ وَالطَّيْرُ

"O mountains, echo [His praises] with him, and the birds!" (author's translation; Qur'an 34:10)

§4.3. Position 3: Righteousness

Sign	AB Number	Linear B	Value	Morphological Function
JA	AB57	B 57 𐎠	/ya/	Root C ₁ of √y-š-r "to be righteous"
SA	AB31	B 31 𐎶	/sa/	Root C ₂ (shin /š/ → SA; doubled to mark sibilant quality)
SA	AB31	B 31 𐎶	/sa/	Root C ₂ (shin marker repeated)
RA	AB60	B 60 𐎠	/ra/	Root C ₃
ME	AB13	B 13 𐎶*	/me/	Mimation (accusative -am)

¹²Ugaritic *dqt* is consonantal; the reconstruction *daqqat* rests on comparison with Hebrew *דקדק* and *דקה* (Gen 41:3; 1 Kgs 19:12; Tropper 2000, 280). The syllabic Linear A spelling DI-KI-TU is the only direct evidence for the Bronze Age vocalization. Theonyms routinely retain archaic or dialectal vocalizations that diverge from the productive adjectival form.

At position 3, we encounter the contentious term JA-SA-SA-RA-ME. In his 1966 reading, Gordon interpreted this exact word as *yašāšālam*, deriving it from $\sqrt{\text{š-l-m}}$ (“to deliver/complete”), or “what is delivered (to a god).” With the corpus available to him then, he supposed that JA in this instance acted as a nominalizing prefix on a verbal stem.

My reading differs, seeing in ME the Semitic phenomenon of accusative mimation -am: *yašāram*, the adverbial accusative from the root $\sqrt{\text{y-š-r}}$. Because the S-series must neutralize all three sibilants (š, s, ṣ), the doubling of SA-SA may signal the phoneme /š/ (shin), comparable to English “ss” representing /ʃ/ in *mission* and *tissue*¹³. The convention was not universally applied: JA-SA-RA (KNZc7) writes the same root with a single SA. At Palaikastro, the word appears without the JA- prefix as both SA-SA-RA-ME (PKZa11) and A-SA-SA-RA (PKZa4, a standalone inscription on a stone vessel). Syllable by syllable, JA-SA-SA-RA-ME appears as a direct analog to Amorite JAŠAR-AM or *Yašaram*.¹⁴

In Akkadian theology, Išartu and her spouse Mīšaru were twin embodiments of righteousness, both derived from the root $\sqrt{\text{e-š-r}}$ (“to be straight, upright”). Notably, at Hagia Triada (HT27a), where we find a tablet headed by TI-NI-TA (cf. the Phoenician Goddess Tinit), I-MI-SA-RA appears as a divine recipient associated with 43 personnel.

Read as /yašāram/, the third word declares the manner in which a deity dwells: “in (the spirit of) righteousness.” The priestess calls upon the Goddess as only the צִדְקֶת (*ṣad-deqet*) can.

Biblical Parallel: Psalm 33:1

רִנְנוּ צְדִיקִים בַּיהוָה לִישְׁרִים נְאֻה תְּהִלָּה

“Cry out, O *ṣaddīqīm*, to YHWH; for the *yěšārīm* praise is fitting.” (author’s translation; text: BHS, p. 1462)

Biblical Parallel: Psalm 15:1–2

יְהוָה מִי־יִגֹּר בְּאֶהֱלֶךְ מִי־יִשְׁכֵּן בְּהַר קִדְשְׁךָ: הוֹלֵךְ תָּמִים וּפֹעֵל צֶדֶק

“YHWH, who may sojourn in Your tent? Who may dwell on Your holy mountain? One who walks in *tamīm* and works *ṣedeq*.” (author’s translation; text: BHS, pp. 1445–1446)

§5. Presentation

§5.1. Position 4: The Gathering

¹³Elsewhere in the corpus, doubled signs may represent geminate consonants: QA-QA-RU is compatible with *qaqqaru* “ground” (HT118, HT122b, HT93a). SA-SA may represent either a true geminate /šš/ or a shin-disambiguation device; the two explanations are not mutually exclusive, since a D-stem intensive of $\sqrt{\text{y-š-r}}$ would produce geminate /šš/ (*yaššar-*) whose doubled spelling also happens to distinguish shin from samekh.

¹⁴Gelb (1980, §6, no. 3448) records JAŠAR-AM (IA-SA-RA-AM), explicitly marked as accusative; cf. *Yašarum* (no. 3449) and *Yašaran* (no. 3486).

Sign	AB Number	Linear B	Value	Morphological Function
U	AB10	B 10 ꜥ	/u/	Presentative particle <i>hunna</i> "behold!"
NA	AB06	B 06 ꜥ̄	/na/	Presentative particle (cont.)
KA	AB77	B 77 ꜥ	/ka/	Root C ₁ of √k-n-s "to gather"
NA	AB06	B 06 ꜥ̄	/na/	Root C ₂
SI	AB41	B 41 ꜥ	/si/	Root C ₃

At position 4, U-NA-KA-NA-SI marks the hinge of the formula, shifting the prayer away from the individual and toward the community. As Linear A has no definite article and cannot render /hu/, U-NA is the closest syllabic approximation to the presentative *hunna*.¹⁵ Hebrew *hinnēh* (cf. Gen 1:29: הִנֵּה נָתַתִּי לָכֶם “Behold, I have given you...”) and Ugaritic *hn* derive from the same Proto-Semitic presentative **han* (Huehnergard 2012, 78; 2019, 68); in the Amarna letters, the presentative particle *annu* “behold” (by-form *allû*) stands in the same relation to Ugaritic *hn* and *hl* (Rainey 1996, III:155–61). In Hebrew, the definite article *ha-*, with assimilated -n (**han-bayt* > *hab-bayt*), retains some trace of this.

U-NA-KA-NA-SI is not unique to IOZa2, but is recorded as a single orthographic unit across three sites on Crete, with no break between U and NA, ruling out a parse as conjunction *wa-* plus a verbal prefix. The corpus attests a spectrum: at its shortest, JA-SA-SARA-ME · U-NA-KA-NA-SI stands alone as a complete two-word prayer (IOZa9, PKZa27); at its longest, U-NA-RU-KA-NA-SI (IOZa16) inserts RU = *lū* (the precative particle “may, let”; cf. Akkadian *lū*, Ugaritic asseverative *l-*; Huehnergard 2012, 78–79) between U-NA and KA-NA-SI, yielding *hunna lū kanasī*—“Behold, may my assembly gather!”

Given the meaning of $\sqrt{k-n-s}$ ("to gather, assemble"), the etymology of nearby Knossos becomes at once self-evident.¹⁶ At Syme (SYZb7), we find a short inscription that reads RA-KI-NI-SE, or *la-kinnisēt*: "for the assembly."

Read as /hunna kanasī/, the fourth word announces: “behold, my assembly!” When parsed as a vocalized vowel, the -ī suffix denotes the 1cs possessive, consistent with the 1cs A- prefix at Position 1.

Ugaritic Parallel: KTU 1.40 (line 8)

l **mp**hrt bn il · l **t**k^umn w šnm · **hn** š

*"To the **assembly** of the sons of El, to Thukamuna and Shunama—**behold**, a ram!" (KTU 1.40; text via Copenhagen Ugaritic Corpus v0.2.7)*

Biblical Parallel: Psalm 33:7

פֶּנֶס כְּנֵד מִי הַיָּם נָתַן בְּאוֹצְרוֹת תְּהוֹמוֹת

¹⁵The /u/ vowel in U-NA (*hunna*), beside Hebrew /i/ in *hinnēh*, is itself noteworthy. Arabic *hunā* ‘here’ preserves a close vocalic parallel, while Ugaritic *hn* is unvocalized. A comparable *u > i development occurs within the Northwest Semitic demonstrative system, where *ulli became *illi in Hebrew, Phoenician, and Aramaic (Hasselbach 2007, 23). I suggest that Minoan U-NA may likewise preserve an older /u/ vocalism.

¹⁶Michael Astour (1966a) detailed an Egyptian topographical list of Amenhotep III (c. 1390 BCE) which likely rendered Knossos as *Ku-nu-sha*. Like many, I wondered if this obscured the pre-Hellenized consonantal skeleton of $\sqrt{k-n-s/\text{š}}$ —the root of Hebrew כְּנַסֶּת (*kneset*) and Aramaic כְּנִישְׁתָּא (*kenishta*). Hebrew כָּנַס had long been considered a late Aramaism (Esther, Nehemiah; HALOT, s.v. כָּנַס); Greenfield (2001, 845–846) demonstrates an etymological and semantic continuum linking this and related roots across Akkadian, Hebrew, and Aramaic.

“Gathering (kōnēs) the waters of the sea as a heap; setting the Tēhōmōt into treasures.”
(author’s translation; text: BHS, p. 1462)

§5.2. Position 5: The Presence

Sign	AB Number	Linear B	Value	Morphological Function
I	AB28	B 28 Ψ	/i/	Preposition <i>in</i> “in”
PI	AB39	B 39 Ṁ	/pi/	Root C ₁ of √p-n-y “face, presence”
NA	AB06	B 06 Ṁ	/na/	Root C ₂
MA	AB80	B 80 Ṁ	/ma/	Mimation (oblique case -am)

At position 5, I-PI-NA-MA functions as the prepositional phrase: *’ipinama*, “in the presence of”—the ritual approach to the deity’s face. The form aligns with Akkadian *ina pāni* “in the face of” (Huehnergard 2011, 100), the older pan-Semitic construction. Hebrew constructs the phrase with *lipnē YHWH* “before the face of YHWH” as the standard priestly formula (Lev 1:3, Num 6:25), just as Phoenician uses *lpn* for “in the presence of” (Krahmalkov 2000, s.v. LPN).

In the Biblical tradition, the face of God bestows blessings; when averted, it portends doom. When the Goddess Tinit goes invoked in Punic Carthage, it is almost always as TNT PN B‘L—“Tinit, Face of Ba‘al” (Hvidberg-Hansen 1979, 15, 18, 27), or the consort of Ba‘al-Ḥammon. Similarly, the “face of God” repeats itself in the Qur’an, albeit from a different root (وَجْه *wajh*, √w-j-h; Qur’an 2:115, 55:27).

Read as /’ipinama/, the fifth word turns the face of the divinity toward the congregation: “in the presence of.”

Ugaritic Parallel: KTU 1.4 IV 20–22 (Baal Cycle)

idk l ttn **pnm** / ‘m ‘il mbk nhrm / qrb ‘apq thmtm

“Then she set her face toward El, at the sources of the Rivers, amid the springs of the Deeps.”
(author’s translation; text: Smith & Pitard 2009, 493)

Biblical Parallel: Numbers 6:25

יָאֵר יְהוָה פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ וִיחַנֶּנּוּ

“May YHWH illuminate His pānāyw upon you, and show you grace.” (author’s translation; text: BHS, p. 341)

§5.3. Position 6: Sacred Ministry

Sign	AB Number	Linear B	Value	Morphological Function
SI	AB41	B 41 Ṁ	/si/	Root C ₁ of √š-r-t “to minister” (sibilant merger: š → s)
RU	AB26	B 26 Ṁ	/ru/	Root C ₂

Sign	AB Number	Linear B	Value	Morphological Function
TE	AB04	B 04 𐀓	/te/	Root C ₃ / nominal suffix -ūt

At position 6, SI-RU-TE completes the prior prepositional phrase, anchoring worship to the divine presence. The sequence I-PI-NA-MA · SI-RU-TE—“in the presence of [the] ministry”—mirrors the Levitical formula *lipnê YHWH lěšārētô* “before the face of YHWH, to minister to Him” (Deut 10:8). As a verbal noun, √š-r-t (“to minister, serve in a sacred capacity”) produces *šīrūt*, the cultic act itself.

In Exodus, Aaron and his sons have the privilege of ministering at the altar of the *miškān* or the Tabernacle (Exod 28:43; 30:20). Before entering the Tent or approaching the altar, they must purify themselves by washing their hands and feet (Exod 30:19–21). Aaron’s ministry is accompanied by the chimes of golden bells sewn onto the hem of his priestly robe, paired with woven pomegranate ornaments (Exod 28:33–35). A Minoan service on the mountaintop likely included the playing of lyres and singing in tandem (Younger 1998, 5–8, 48–49), echoing the description of Levite musicians in the post-exilic period (1 Chr 6:32).

Read as /šīrūt/, the sixth word conjures the melodies, the incense, and the priestly splendor of “sacred worship.”

Biblical Parallel: Numbers 3:6

הַקָּרֵב אֶת־מִטָּה לִּי וְהַעֲמִדְתָּ אֹתוֹ לִפְנֵי אֶהֱרֹן הַכֹּהֵן וְשָׂרְתוּ אִתּוֹ

“Bring near the tribe of Lewi and set them before Aaron the priest, and they shall **minister** (**wěšērētû**) to him.” (author’s translation; text: BHS, p. 328)

Biblical Parallel: Deuteronomy 10:8

בַּעֲתָהּ הָיָה הַבְּדִיל יְהוָה אֶת־שִׁבְטֵי הַלֵּוִי לְשֵׂאת אֶת־אֲרוֹן בְּרִית־יְהוָה לַעֲמֹד לִפְנֵי יְהוָה לְשָׂרְתוֹ וּלְבָרֵךְ בְּשֵׁמוֹ עַד הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה

“At that time YHWH set apart the tribe of Lewi to carry the ark of the covenant of YHWH—to stand before the face of YHWH, **to minister to Him** (**lěšārētô**), and to bless in His name.” (author’s translation; text: BHS, p. 460)

§6. Reception

§6.1. Position 7: The Closing Petition

Sign	AB Number	Linear B	Value	Morphological Function
TA	AB59	B 59 𐀀	/ta/	3fs prefix (“may she/it”)
NA	AB06	B 06 𐀁	/na/	N-stem morpheme (preserved before /r/)
RA	AB60	B 60 𐀂	/ra/	Root C ₁ of √r-ṣ-y “to accept, be pleased with”
TE	AB04	B 04 𐀃	/te/	Root C ₂ (emphatic neutralization: ṣ → t)
U	AB10	B 10 𐀄	/ū/	Prefix-conjugation vowel *-u (PS *yaqtulu)
TI	AB37	B 37 𐀅	/ti/	2nd person object suffix (archaic *-t-series)
NU	AB55	B 55 𐀆	/nū/	Energic nun + vocalic extension

At the seventh and final position, TA-NA-RA-TE-U-TI-NU beckons us back to our rules of Semitic verbal morphology. The most morphologically dense word in the inscription, it also reveals for us the gender of the minister herself.

The TA- morpheme designates this as a 3fs verb, in contrast to the 1cs A-TA-I-³⁰¹WA-JA which initiated the prayer. The NA- that follows represents the N-stem (nip^{al}) morpheme, preserved before /r/ where later Hebrew assimilates it: Biblical תִּרְצֶה *tērāṣeh* < *tinaraṣī. In Biblical Hebrew, the N-stem of √r-ṣ-y is the standard verb of liturgical acceptance, לוֹ וְנִרְצָה “and it shall be accepted for him” (Lev 1:4), לֹא יִרְצָה “it shall not be accepted” (Lev 7:18), in the exact register a closing petition demands.¹⁷

The root is the distinctly NWS √r-ṣ-y “to accept, be pleased with.” I propose that Linear A represents emphatic ṣade through its T-series, further evidenced by the Zakros (ZA7a) inscription A-RE-TU-MI, or *³arṣ-ummī, “Earth is my mother”—the likely origin of Greek Ἀρτεμις.¹⁸

Between the verb root and object suffix, the U vowel occupies precisely the slot where Proto-Semitic places the indicative *-u of the *yaqtulu conjugation. Ugaritic preserves -u in this position when pronominal suffixes follow: *ārgmk* /ʔargumu-kī/ “I will say to you

¹⁷Professor Gary Rendsburg noted the likeness to the nip^{al} form, citing Lev 1:4: וְנִרְצָה לוֹ לְכַפֵּר עָלָיו “and it shall be accepted for him, to make atonement on his behalf.”

¹⁸Lydian *Artimu-* preserves a /u/ vowel absent from the Greek *Artemis*. Linear B *a-te-mi-to* (PY Es 650, genitive) drops the pre-consonantal /r/ per orthographic convention. At Mari (c. 1810–1760 BCE), goddess+*ummī* names are ubiquitous, e.g., Eštar-ummī (ARM 23, 610:7); see Nakata 1995, 238, 244, for the full inventory.

(fs)” (KTU 1.3 iii:21; Huehnergard 2012, §IV.D.4).

In the penultimate syllable, the suffix *-TI* represents the 2nd person object pronoun from the archaic **-t-* series, older than the **-k-* series (**-ka/*-ki*) that replaced it in all attested Semitic. The 2nd person morpheme **-t-* belongs to the deepest stratum of Afroasiatic¹⁹, retained in the independent pronouns (**ʾanta/*ʾatti*), the suffix conjugation (**-ta/*-ti*), and the prefix conjugation prefix (*ta-*). Pat-El reconstructs the 2fs suffix **-ti* to Proto-Semitic as one of the most stable person markers in the family, from Akkadian stative *marṣ-ā-ti* to Arabic perfect *qatal-ti* (Pat-El 2025, 329, 332). The bound object and possessive functions, by contrast, are reconstructed with **-k-* in Proto-Semitic (Lipiński 1997, §36). Minoan, which maintains case vowels, mimation, and N-stem /n/ that later NWS languages lost, may preserve the object suffix at its pre-innovation stage.

The final NU functions, potentially, as an energetic *-n*, the same emphatic verbal suffix that appears productively in Ugaritic (*yaqtulan* or *yaqtulanna*; Huehnergard 2012, 54, 57–58; Huehnergard and Rubin 2011, 271) and Amarna Canaanite (*mīna ipušūna anāku* “What can I do?”, EA 74:63–64; Rainey 1996, II:234–44), surviving as a frozen relic in archaic Biblical Hebrew (paragogic nun: יְהִרְסוּן, Ps 11:3). Its enunciation after the object suffix *-TI-*, rather than before it, reverses the expected Semitic ordering but matches the fixed clitic template of Berber, where object markers precede directional particles (Dell and Elmedlaoui 2002, 19–22).

Read as /tana-raṣē-ū-tī-nū/, the seventh word is a closing petition: “may she be accepted for you.” The N-stem shifts the direction of the verb from “she accepts” to “she is accepted,” while permitting some spiritual ambiguity. The 3fs prefix *TA-* admits three feminine referents simultaneously: *šrūt* (the sacred worship at position 6), the Goddess whose face was invoked at position 5, and the priestess herself, the officiant declaring her own fitness to intercede. At the height of ritual, these three collapse into one: “Descending from on high, she personifies the mountain that receives her” (Nagy 2021, §1).

Biblical Parallel: Isaiah 56:7

וְהֵבִיאֹתִים אֶל־הָר קֹדֶשׁ וְשִׁמְחָתִים בְּבֵית תַּפְלָתִי עוֹלָתֵיהֶם וְזִבְחֵיהֶם לְרָצוֹן עַל־מִזְבְּחִי כִּי בֵּיתִי בֵּית־תַּפְלָה יִקְרָא לְכָל־עַמִּים:

“I will bring them to My holy mountain and gladden them in My house of prayer; their burnt offerings and their sacrifices shall be **acceptable (lērāṣōn)** upon My altar, for My house shall be called a house of prayer for all peoples.” (author’s translation; text: BHS, p. 1058)

Biblical Parallel: Psalm 19:15

יְהִי־לְרָצוֹן אִמְרֵי־פִי וְהִגִּיוֹן לִבִּי לִפְנֵיךָ יְהוָה צוּרִי וְגֹאֲלִי

“Let the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be **acceptable (lērāṣōn)** before your face (lěpānēkā), O YHWH, my rock and my redeemer.” (author’s translation; text: BHS, p. 1451)

¹⁹Lipiński suggests that prehistoric Afroasiatic may have alternated between *t* and *k* in its second-person morphology, as reflected in reconstructed *an-ti* beside *an-ki* (1997, §§36.5–6, 40.5). This offers a possible precedent for Minoan retaining dental *-t-* in a second-person feminine suffix.

§7. The Translation

The mountain peak libation formula, as represented at IOZa2, is thus reconstructed:

A-TA-I-NA-WA-JA · JA-DI-KI-TU · JA-SA-SA-RA-ME · U-NA-KA-NA-SI · I-PI-NA-MA
· SI-RU-TE · TA-NA-RA-TE-U-TI-NU · I

Position	Linear A	Reading	Translation
1. Invocation	A-TA-I-NA-WA-JA	/ˈatainawayə/	“I make myself a dwelling”
2. Sacred Mountain	JA-DI-KI-TU	/yā Diqqitu/	“O Diqqitu!”
3. Righteousness	JA-SA-SA-RA-ME	/yašāram/	“in (the spirit of) righteousness”
4. Assembly	U-NA-KA-NA-SI	/hunna kanasī/	“Behold, my assembly!”
5. Theophany	I-PI-NA-MA	/ˈipinama/	“in the presence of”
6. Sacred Ministry	SI-RU-TE	/šrūt/	“sacred worship”
7. Petition	TA-NA-RA-TE-U-TI-NU	/tana-rašē-ū-tī-nū/	“May she be accepted for you”
8.	I	CH 008, “hand” ²⁰	(untranslated)

I make myself a dwelling—O Diqqitu!—in (the spirit of) righteousness. Behold, my assembly, in the presence of sacred worship. May she be accepted for you.

Read and recited in full, “Ya Diktu” is the oldest liturgical prayer in the Northwest Semitic canon, anticipating the Ugaritic ritual tablets by two centuries, and the earliest Biblical poetry by three.²¹ Much like the Levitical liturgies, it tells us that Minoan theophany in its Middle period concerned itself with the dwelling of the godhead on Earth, and the conditions by which an officiant might approach said deity. Where the Psalmist asks, “who may dwell” and “who may ascend your mountain?” (Ps 15:1; 24:3), the priestess of Mt. Iouktas answers: “my assembly.” Although the root differs, the Minoan prayer is bound up in the same theology as the מִשְׁכָּן *miškān* and the שְׁכִינָה *šēkīnā* (Lev 26:11), albeit through *nawā*.²² By the Late Minoan, on an allocation tablet at Hagia Triada (HT116a), we glean the term SI-KI-NE (*šikinēt*) in the position of a recipient, mirroring the PO-TI-NI-JA (*potnia*) of Linear B (PY Fn 187). Ostensibly, *Diqqitu* recalls the Mycenaean *Potnia Theron*;

²⁰GORILA transcribes the last legible sign on IO Za 2 as AB28 (I), though the head-shaped form may be a distinct sign (Salgarella 2020, 337–338). A following divider separates AB28 (I) from a tentative AB01 (DA) that begins a lost ninth word-group. The fragmentary IO Za 11 likewise preserves]U-TI-NU · I-NA-I-DA[, showing that the prayer could continue. Psalm 19:15 supplies a typological parallel which closes with a theonym and epithets, “YHWH, my rock and my redeemer” (author’s translation). IO Za 2 may have ended similarly, but its coda is now beyond restoration.

²¹The Ugaritic ritual tablets KTU 1.40 and KTU 1.119 likely date to the 13th century BCE. The Song of the Sea (Exod 15:1–18) and the Song of Deborah (Judg 5) inhabit the 12th–11th century BCE (Cross & Freedman 1975, 2; Rendsburg 2019, 443).

²²The association between assembly (√k-n-s) and divine indwelling (√š-k-n) is explicit in rabbinic tradition. The Talmud (Berakhot 6a) establishes that the *šēkīnā* is present wherever ten gather for prayer—the *minyān*. The Zohar similarly says: “Then the holy people must join together in the synagogue (*bē kēnishtā*), and whoever arrives first is joined with the *šēkīnā* in a single union” (Zohar II, 131a; author’s translation; Pritzker Aramaic text, vol. 5, p. 222).

but the latter's cult is one of imitation, of the *nouveau régime* seeking legitimacy, if not assimilation into the old ways. As Lupack argues, "Mycenaean religion evolved through appropriations from the Minoans" (Lupack 2023, 67).

Purification of body and soul is no less a central concept to the Iouktas libation. To minister in righteousness, to receive the רִיחַ הַקֹּדֶשׁ (*rūaḥ ha-qōdeš*), the צִדְקָה (*šaddeqet*) herself must be perfect. In an echo of Psalm 25:21 (*tōm wāyōšer*), we find TU-ME paired with JA-SA-SA-[RA] (PKZa14), and TU-ME-I with JA-SA-... (PKZa8) on two stone vessels at Palaikastro. On Gordon's famous 'agānu prayer bowl (KNZc7), the term DU-RA-RE (√d-r-r "to purify, be free") precedes what I read as A-TH-RA²³ (ʾAṭirat), followed by the familiar JA-SA-RA. At this, we are obliged to revisit Jane E. Harrison in her discussion on mystery: "The ancients themselves were not quite comfortable about the connection with μύω. They knew and felt that mystery, secrecy, was not the main gist of 'a mystery': the essence of it all primarily was purification" (Harrison 1908, 154). Like King Keret of the Ugaritic texts (KTU 1.14 II:9–26), the Minoan undergoes many rituals, recounts many incantations, that she may "handle certain sacra" (Harrison 1908, 154), and be worthy to stand in the face of her Goddess. She prays not for herself but for her tribe, unifying the living and the dead, the future and the past.

While we may have only one dominant prayer formula from Iouktas, excavations at the site conveyed their own stories. We know from the multitude of pouring and drinking vessels recovered at the mountaintop that its stone altars were indeed built for libations.²⁴ Alongside the ceramics, the sanctuary's terraces contained a collection of animal bones in their ashen layers, indicative of communal feasts. Cromarty posits that the lack of calcination implies the animals were cooked rather than consumed by fire (Cromarty 2007, 2:99–100). We might compare this to a kosher or halal practice, where the meat is distributed among the worshipers. In Ugaritic texts, this was called a *marzeaḥ* banquet, and in Leviticus the שְׁלָמִים *šlāmîm*, a peace offering eaten communally (Lev 3; 7:11–15). After the skeletal remains of sheep, goats, pigs, and birds, we encounter again the clay figurines. Beyond goats, the trove extended to bovines, dogs, beetles, and snakes, replete with scorch marks. In Akkadian spells of the first millennium BCE, we read of a *maqlû* in which similar clay, wax, and tallow creations were burnt on the brazier as incantations were repeated (Schwemer 2014; Maqlû VII 183–92). Deut 7:5 shifts the tenor of the ceremony as it declares, "the graven images of their gods you shall burn with fire."

Above all, the Minoan Mystery was sung in the presence of the community, on the mountaintop, in the open air. By the Classical era, it remained a public affair, in contrast to

²³ A rare and enigmatic sign, AB79 (𐀓) represents the only dedicated symbol for the voiceless interdental fricative /t/ in Linear A. As the sole sign covering the entire t-series, it is necessarily vowel-agnostic. Under this hypothesis, the inherent /u/ is a dead vowel (cf. Gordon 1966a, §§138, 147), expendable when syllabic scripts notate Semitic (Hawkins 2016, 244; Kilani 2019; cf. Salgarella 2023, 406 on Linear B's identical convention). Given that AB79 appears in only 25 word-forms across Linear A, scribal convention clearly favored its sublimation into the T-series. See Appendix A for attestations and the full KNZc7 translation.

²⁴ Harrison argued that this was a honey drink, one of the "wineless libations" (*nephalia*) characteristic of pre-Olympian religion (Harrison 1908, 90). It should be reiterated that Classical Cretans were not ordinary drinkers. Plato reports that symposia were neither customary nor lawful on the island (*Laws* I.639d–640a; cf. *Minos* 320a–b); and an archaic inscription at Eleutherna, Crete prohibits intoxication outright, with priests denied even the communal exception (SEG 41.739). Being a teetotal myself, I recognized this kinship long ago.

the Mysteries of Eleusis and Samothrace, both of which were said to derive from Crete.²⁵ Diodorus Siculus writes, “At Knossos the custom from ancient times was that these rites should be communicated openly and to all, and things that among the other peoples were communicated in secrecy among the Cretans no one concealed from any one who wished to know” (Diod. Sic. 5.77.3; trans. Harrison 1908, 566).

§8. Cross-Site Variation

Position	IOZa2 (Iouktas)	IOZa6 (Iouktas Inati)	TLZa1 (Troullos)	KOZa1 (Kophinas)	PKZa11 (Palaikastro)	SYZa3 (Syme)
1. Invocation	A-TA-I- [*] 301-WA-JA	TA-NA-I- [*] 301-U-TI-NU	A-TA-I- [*] 301-WA-JA	A-TA-I- [*] 301-WA-JA	A-TA-I- [*] 301-WA-E	A-TA-I- [*] 301-WA-JA
2. Deity / Site	JA-DI-KI-TU	I-NA-TA · I- [*] 79-DI-SI-KA	O-SU-QA-RE	TU-RU-SA · DU- [*] 314-RE · I-DA-A	A-DI-KI-TE-TE	—
3. Righteousness	JA-SA-SA-RA-ME	JA-SA-SA-RA-ME	JA-SA-SA-RA-ME	—	SA-SA-RA-ME	—
4. Gathering	U-NA-KA-NA-SI	—	U-NA-KA-NA	U-NA-KA-NA-SI	U-NA- RU -KA-NA- TI	SE-KA-NA-SI
5. Presence	I-PI-NA-MA	—	I-PI-NA-MA	I-PI-NA-MA	I-PI-NA- MI -NA	—
6. Sacred Ministry	SI-RU-TE	—	SI-RU-TE	SI-RU-TE	SI-RU	SI-RU-TE
7. Petition	TA-NA-RA-TE-U-TI-NU	—	—	—	—	—

Were the mountain peak libation formula confined to Iouktas, its detractors would be on flat, if not shaky ground to challenge Linear A’s classification as Semitic. The fact is that it recurs with minor variations across at least five peak sanctuaries and cave sites, spanning the full breadth of Crete—from Palaikastro in the east to Troullos and Kophinas in the south, with Syme in between. If we expand to fragments, the count rises to 28 stone vessels and 11 sites c. 1800–1450 BCE. These variations are a grammatical paradigm, a theological map, and a testimony to the spiritual beliefs of the Bronze Age Minoans.

We begin again at Iouktas (IOZa6) where we see the most pronounced deviation. The inscription opens not with $\sqrt{n-w-y}$ but a verb from the root $\sqrt{‘-n-y}$, followed by the words I-NA-TA · I-TH-DI-SI-KA and finally JA-SA-SA-RA-ME. Given what we have already learned by solving for IOZa2, the verbal form in the first position is an N-stem 3fs jussive with energetic *nun*, rendered TA-NA-I-NA-U-TI-NU, *tanainautīnū* (“may she answer for you”). I-NA-TA is certainly the Minoan doublet of Ugaritic Anat and Biblical Anath, confirming the etymology of her name through a theophoric pun.²⁶ But this is a decid-

²⁵By our best estimates, the Classical pilgrimage from Athens to partake in the Eleusinian rites cost half a month’s wage—a minimum of fifteen drachmas for initiation alone (IG II² 1672, line 207; Karatas 2018, 73–74). After defeating Mark Antony at Actium, Augustus had the Greater Mysteries celebrated out of season while still in Greece (Cass. Dio 54.9.10). Centuries later, the Roman emperor Marcus Aurelius also partook (Cass. Dio 72.31.3).

²⁶I propose that ‘Anat derives from the root $\sqrt{‘-n-y}$ “to answer, respond” (Ugaritic *‘ny*, Hebrew *נָתַן*; Huehn-ergard 2012, s.vv. *‘nt*, $\sqrt{‘ny}$). When the verb *tanainautīnu* (“may she answer for you”) precedes the theonym *‘Inat* (“she who answers”), we observe a degree of wordplay at hand.

edly different Anat—one who has yet to differentiate from the Mother Goddess Athirat.²⁷ I-TH-DI-SI-KA is vocalized as the compound epithet, *I-Thadi Siqqa*, “the breast that gives drink.”²⁸ We should recall two Ugaritic lines of note: “[Islanders, sons of the s]ea, who suck at the nipples of the breasts of Asherah” (KTU 1.23:23–24; Gordon 1966b, 95) and the scene from the Danel saga in which his daughter Pughat “gives drink to the warrior Yatpan” and “he then answers” (KTU 1.19 IV:54–56; author’s translation; text: Copenhagen Ugaritic Corpus v0.2.7; Gordon 1966b, 139).

Stepping away from Iouktas, we find the most striking variations of the “Ya Diktu” formula at its second position, where each sanctuary names its respective deity. At Troullos, this is O-SU-QA-RE, vocalized as *O-Sukar*, with a prosthetic aleph. An Old Kingdom deity, Sukar (or Sokar in Coptic) oversaw the chthonic realm as *Rosetau*, “Lord of the Entrance to the Underworld,” at the Giza necropolis. By the Middle Kingdom, contemporary with the Minoan Protopalatial, his cult had syncretized with that of Ptah and Osiris,²⁹ forming a trinity regarded at Memphis as gods and judges of the Duat; in Memphite theology, Ptah exercised creative power through his tongue and command of speech (Bernal 2006, 569; Lichtheim 1973, 51–57).

On the Kophinas mountaintop, TU-RU-SA goes invoked in position two, preceding the words DU-*314-RE · I-DA-A.³⁰ In Semitic, the root $\sqrt{t-r-s}$ means “to shield, protect, fortify,” *du* acts as a possessive element (cf. Arabic *dhū* in *ذُو الْقُرْنَيْنِ* *Dhū l-Qarnayn*, “the one of the two horns”), and $\sqrt{h-r-r}$ translates as “noble and freeborn.” As any Classicist will remember, it is at Mt. Ida where the Idaean Daktyls³¹ were said to dwell. Diodorus identifies them with the Kabeiroi³², mentioning that at Samothrace “they used an ancient language which was peculiar to them and of which many words are preserved to this day in the ritual of their sacrifices” (Diod. Sic. 5.47.3). Substantively, the Kabeiroi are the

²⁷Hanat is attested at Mari under Zimri-Lim in the name *Ummi-Hanat* (c. 1780–1758 BCE; ARM 23, 159:5), while *ha-na-tum* is explicitly equated with Ishtar in the Amorite-Akkadian bilingual (George & Krebernik, *RA* 116, 2022). In KTU 1.15 II:25–28, Yaššib *ynq ḥlb aṭrt mšš ḏd btlṭ ‘nt mšnqt*—“sucks the milk of Athirat, suckles the breast of the maiden Anat, the wet nurses” (Gordon 1966b, 111).

²⁸In the Ugaritic alphabet, the 30th letter renders the voiceless interdental fricative of *Athirat* and *Thadi*. $\aleph$, however, sometimes alternates with the sibilant *z* or the voiced interdental $\aleph$ (*zd* and $\aleph d$ for $\aleph d$ “breast” in KTU 1.23:24, 59; cf. KTU 1.4 VI:56). Linear B scribes appeared to utilize *AB79 in much the same way, albeit as a vowel-specific sign, compared to its agnostic Linear A predecessor.

²⁹Osiris may be attested in Linear A at Phaistos (PH(?)31a) recorded as AB85-SI-RE or AU-SI-RE (cf. Coptic *Ousire*), beside MA-DI (𐎎𐎗𐎛 *mō‘ēd*, “appointed festival”). AB85 bucks the syllabogram trend as a VV diphthong, in the same vein as Linear B *a₃ / AI/* (Judson 2020, ch. 2; Palaima 2020, 5–7).

³⁰*314 $\aleph$, here read as the pharyngeal $\aleph$ absent from Linear B, is attested six times in the Linear A corpus (Hagia Triada, Kophinas, Phaistos, Arkhalokhori). I-DA-A writes the bare toponym *Ida*, paired with a final directive suffix (the Semitic *hē locale*, Hebrew -āh), marking destination: “toward Ida” (Huehnergard 2012, §IV.B.5, 40).

³¹Chantraine classifies $\aleph d\eta$ as non-Indo-European (*DELG*, s.v. $\aleph d\eta$). If *Ida* relates to the Semitic **yad* (Hebrew *yad* “hand,” Akkadian *idu* “arm”), as the Linear A gentilic JE-DI (*yedī* “the Idaean,” four attestations at Hagia Triada) may corroborate, then $\delta\acute{\alpha}\kappa\tau\upsilon\lambda\omicron\iota$ “fingers” supplies the Greek translation; “Idaean Daktyls” reads “fingers of the hand” (cf. Pollux, *Onom.* 2.156: οἱ τῆς χειρὸς δάκτυλοι τεχνῖται τε καὶ πάντων ἐργάται, “the fingers of the hand are craftsmen and workers of all things”). The Aegean abounds in such doublets, among them Kythera from Semitic *keter* “crown,” confirmed by its port Skandeia (Astour 1965a, 143), and Rheneia from Hebrew *rānan* “to shout,” doubled by Greek Keladussa “tumultuous” (Astour 1964, 195).

³²Hebrew *kabbīr* “great, mighty” ($\sqrt{k-b-r}$; Movers 1841, 527–538; Meyer 1931, 119). Astour connects the Greek Kabeiroi to the seven “good and fair gods” of the Ugaritic birth hymn (KTU 1.23), headed by *Šaḥar* (Dawn) and *Šalim* (Dusk), called “sons of the Sea” and “islanders” (Astour 1965a, 155–156).

same as the Korybantes, and most crucially, the Kouretes—the half-men, half-daimones explored so deftly by Harrison in *Themis*. It is their Palaikastro Hymn, of presumed antiquity, that tells us how “the shielded nurturers took thee, a child immortal, from Rhea” (Harrison 1912, 7). Curiously, the term Tursha (Egyptian *twršš*) appears under Merneptah as one of the Sea Peoples, and again on the Medinet Habu relief (Manassa 2003).

Lingering among the Kabeiroi, we come to a formula variant recorded not on a mountaintop, but in a storeroom of Zakros (ZA Zb 3). Its sequence includes A-SA-MU-NE, which I read as *Ashmun*, otherwise known as the Phoenician god Eshmun; later comes A-TA-I-301-DE-KA, here read as *’ata-i-nay-dēka*, “who answered for you,” a variant of the formula’s usual opening term. Philo of Byblos, transmitting the writings of Sanchuniathon (*Sakon-yaton*, “Sakon has given”), shares that the eighth son of Sydyk was Asclepius, the Greek counterpart of Eshmun (Eusebius, *Praep. Ev.* I.10). He goes on to say that Sydyk’s sons were the Dioskouroi, or Kabeiroi, or Korybantes, or Samothracians. In his *Hellenosemitica* (238–239), Astour endorsed Assmann’s derivation of Korybas from a reconstructed **qarub-ba’al* “attendant of Baal,” citing the *Hanniba’al* > *Annibas* parallel. Familiar with Harrison himself, Astour went on to parallel the Idaean Kouretes with the *rpum* of the Ugaritic tablets, Ba’al’s seven attendants in the Underworld. The leader of these *rpum*, the Rapu Ba’al, “Lord of Healing,” would elegantly explain the origin of A-SA-MU-NE, as well as the Megistos Kouros of the Palaikastro Hymn.³³

Before moving on, the perceptive reader will discern an isogloss at the Palaikastro site (PK Za 11). The initial JA is consistently dropped: SA-SA-RA-ME for JA-SA-SA-RA-ME, -WA-E for -WA-JA, A-DI-KI-TE-TE for JA-DI-KI-TU. As a dialectal feature, this weakening of *yod* may extend to the eastern shore of Zakros, where we find A-TA-NA (ZA 9)—precursor to Linear B A-TA-NA-PO-TI-NI-JA (KN V 52)—in which the standard Knossian form would be JA-TA-NA, the feminine reflex of *√y-t-n*, “to give” (cf. Phoenician *Ba’al Yatōn*, “Ba’al has given”). The name then means “She-who-gives” and is, in all likelihood, the etymon of Greek *Ἀθήνα*, the Goddess who bestows wisdom.³⁴

§9. Typological Diagnostics

While I have taken a largely philological approach to the deciphering of Linear A, linguists have long attempted to study the syllabary and its corpus through formal and statistical methods. Davis, recipient of the 2019 Ventris Award, pioneered a typological approach to Linear A, isolating the structural features of the Minoan language without presupposing a language family classification. In 2013 he proposed that the libation formula exhibited VSO word order, substituting ideograms in an inscription at Syme (SY Za 2; Davis 2013, 38–42). In the past year, he contributed to Salgarella & Petrakis’s *The Wor(l)ds of Linear A*, expanding upon his prior work by applying Greenberg’s implicational universals to Minoan. When Davis examined Linear A affixes like A-TA, JA-TA, TA-NA, -WA-JA, and

³³Eshmun is securely attested from 754 BCE as a divine witness in the Assyrian treaty of Ashur-nirari V and Mati’ilu of Arpad (SAA 2 2, rev. vi 22). His identification with Asclepius is confirmed by the trilingual inscription from San Nicolò Gerrei, Sardinia (CIS I 143): Punic *l’šmn*, Greek *Ἀσκληπιῶ*, Latin *Aesculapio*. The fourteenth-century London Medical Papyrus may also preserve *’šmn* (“Eshmun, our father”) and *rp’y* (“my Healer”) in separate Northwest Semitic incantations (Steiner 1992, 194, 198–199).

³⁴Greek and Latin sometimes rendered the /t/ of Phoenician *√y-t-n* as th/θ: *Ba’al-yatōn* → *Baliathon*, *Baliatho*; *Yatōn-ba’al* → *Ithumbal* (Krahmalkov 2000, s.v. B’LYTN, YTNB’L).

U-TI-NU, he concluded they were markers of a multisyllabic morphology, eliminating the possibility of a Semitic identification which typically employs monosyllabic prefixes and suffixes. By this premise alone, one could argue that Davis treated sign count in Linear A as a proxy for morpheme count. Accordingly, Mycenaean Greek in Linear B would not withstand the same scrutiny. A poignant case in point: the word *ἄνθρωπος* (three syllables) requires four Linear B signs to spell *a-to-ro-qo* (PY Ta 722). We, however, know how to interpret these signs and form *an-thro-pos* because of the phonological rules developed by Ventris and Chadwick. Just so, Cyrus Gordon gifted us the laws by which to discern the telltale signs of the Semitic language encoded within Linear A (Gordon 1966a, 26–27).

As each sign in Linear A is an open syllable, it imposes systematic distortions on Semitic phonology. Stops cannot be distinguished as voiced, voiceless, or emphatic; all sibilants merge into a single S-series; laryngeals are not (always) even written, but represented by a “pure vowel” sign; and neither consonantal nor vocalic length is ever indicated orthographically.³⁵ Despite all this, Linear A is the only pre-Classical Semitic script that renders full vocalization on every syllable. It gives us the vowel morphology, the Barth-Ginsberg prefix, the tG stem, even case endings that go invisible in later consonantal scripts; and unlike the polyvalence of Akkadian cuneiform, its readings are much more constrained. Paradoxically, it may prove to be the most transparent window into Bronze Age Semitic linguistics.

After discussing affixes, Davis turns to what he calls the “Valério hypothesis,” showing how internal comparisons across Linear A, Linear B, and Classical sources can elucidate individual terms within the corpus. He settles on the peak sanctuary of Petsofas and the sequence A-DI-KI-TE-TE DU-PU₂-RE (PK Za 11, 12, 15) with its connection to the famous Knossos Linear B inscription DA-PU₂-RI-TO-JO PO-TI-NI-JA, *me-ri* (KN Gg 702). Coincidentally, Valério, Davis, and I converged on reading DU-PU₂-RE as “sanctuary” (Davis 2026, 49–50). The nearest analog to DU-PU₂-RE, or DU-BU-RE, as Davis correctly renders it, would be the Hebrew דָּבֶרֶת *Daberat*, the Levitical city at the foot of Mt. Tabor (Joshua 21:28), as well as the Ge‘ez *dabr*, “mountain, monastery” (Leslau, CDG, s.v. *dabr*), and the Hebrew דְּבִיר *debir*, the Holy of Holies (1 Kings 6:16). But it is in fact Linear B DA-PU₂-RI-TO which most interested me years ago. Vainstub (2011) had observed structural parallels between the prophetess Deborah and the ibex Jael, and the Cretan Melissa and the she-goat Amaltheia. With this knowledge of *√d-b-r*’s versatility, I resolved that *307, much like *301, functioned logographically, specifically for Semitic *dubur*, on the grounds that it occurred in the exact same spot as DU at PKZa8, and acted as a header on Hagia Triada administrative tablets. At HT27a, it follows TI-NI-TA, denoting a sanctuary or *debir* of the Minoan serpent goddess.

Ultimately, the VSO paradigm that Davis espouses for Linear A suits Hebrew, Phoenician, Ugaritic, and Minoan perfectly. Likewise, all the Greenberg universals he invokes also describe the Northwest Semitic languages. In his analysis of Afroasiatic verbs, he neglects the derived stems which yielded the archaic state we saw in the first position of “Ya Diktu”, A-TA-I. Nonetheless, Davis’s work and methodology remain valid, and I

³⁵Koller describes the Old Assyrian merchants at Kanesh (c. 1950–1750 BCE) operating in the exact same way: “They collapsed differences between voiced and unvoiced consonants, did not indicate vowel length, and reduced the number of signs needed to under seventy rather than the 600 then in use in Old Babylonian” (Koller 2024, 129).

welcome his input on a 508-entry lexicon, 42 resolved signs, and 443 full translations that I have tested and amassed in the authoring of this paper.³⁶

§10. Epilegomena

The Minoans bequeathed a great portion to the civilizations that followed them. Cyrus Gordon went so far as to say they were “the basic civilizing factor” of Achaean Greece and Israel (Gordon 1954, 131) given their mythical prestige in the eastern Mediterranean. Because Linear A could not be fully deciphered, some argued that the line separating the Minoan and the Mycenaean was purely imaginary, tethered to a fantasy of a graceful, peaceful, and artistic matriarchy which never truly existed (Gere 2009). Informed now by their art and their language, we have the proper lens with which to respond to this, and other spurious claims on the nature of Semitic worship.³⁷

Starting with the material, Barbara Olsen draws a crucial distinction: “In contrast to the numerous kouroutrophoi from the Mycenaean mainland, images placing women with young children are virtually absent from Minoan art ... Minoan society does not invest in idealizing women as mothers ... Above all, emphasis is on the social rather than the biological, the public rather than the domestic” (Olsen 1998, 388, 390). After the destruction of Knossos in c. 1425 BCE, we can infer that the Mycenaeans imposed a formally patriarchal social structure upon the island, appropriating the role of officiant at Iouktas where the archaeological layer stretches until c. 1200 BCE (Peatfield 1983, 277–78). Although we still see traces of women conducting ceremonies on the Hagia Triada sarcophagus, and a “preponderance of hierieiai [priestesses] at Pylos and Knossos,” a cultural and religious shift had taken effect (Ventris and Chadwick 1956, 281; cf. Downing 1985). In the Late Minoan II (c. 1470–1420 BCE), the Mountain Mother sealing from Knossos depicts a goddess figure emerging from the rock, flanked by two lions, as she hands a staff to a male figure who is much larger in stature than her (Peatfield 1983, 278). Rutkowski interprets this in kind: “the goddess of the peak sanctuaries [is] endowing the king with her divine authority and power, to be her earthly representative” (Peatfield 1983, 278; Rutkowski 1972, 173).

Inscriptions in Linear A come to an abrupt halt in 1450 BCE, coinciding with the sacking of the palatial centers across the island. While some contend that the Minoan syllabary endured another century,³⁸ the newly crowned Mycenaeans instructed their Semitic scribes to adapt Linear A to meet the needs of an Indo-European language. As

³⁶In formal response to Davis (2026), I have included a comprehensive appendix of 67 Linear A sign-groups matching his own. Of these, 39 (58.2%) are hapax legomena. Under my own ruling, a hapax remains speculative unless independently corroborated by structural, contextual, ideographic, or quantitative evidence.

³⁷Since the myth of the Minotaur, Minoans have been targets of blood libel. The five archaeological sites most often cited as evidence span 1,500 years and four distinct cultures, with the most recent (730 BCE) being Dorian. At several of these sites, alternative analyses identify excarnation or other forms of mortuary processing (Hughes 1991, 13–22; Müller Celka 2016, 547–556; Driessen 2010, 107–118). Soles (2010) documents skull curation, feasting with the dead, and other practices consistent with ancestor worship. The readiness to identify human sacrifice in ambiguous deposits may itself be historically conditioned.

³⁸Salgarella & Petrakis (2026, Table 1) classify Linear A as “non-administrative, residual?” during LM IIIA1 (c. 1400–1370 BCE), placing it in coexistence with Linear B for 50–90 years. At least two inscriptions survive the destruction horizon: KN Ze 16, a stone block from the Kephala Tholos at Knossos, probably LM II (Owens 1998–99, 150), and POZc1, an inked dedication on a clay figurine from Poros Herakleiou, securely LM IIIA (Olivier, Dimopoulou, and Rethemiotakis 1993).

Greek lacks pharyngeals, emphatics, and interdental fricatives, signs were either dropped or repurposed for completely different Greek phonemes. At the same time, the Mycenaeans commissioned some twelve to twenty new signs, seven of them o-vowel, covering the o-column, diphthongs, and consonant clusters that a Semitic syllabary did not require (Salgarella 2023, 411; Olivier 2024, 71–72). On the occasions when a Semitic term needed rendering, signs like AB79 could be restored to their original sound—Salgarella herself entertains that the first Linear B writers were bilinguals (Salgarella 2023, 400).

In the midst of Linear B's formal ascendancy, repeated mainland invasions led to a mixing of populations across the isle, most especially in eastern Crete (Tsipopoulou 2009, 134). Having dramatically reduced their activity at peak sanctuaries since the Theran eruption, the eastern Cretans were eventually “pushed out of Crete by the increasing presence and power of the Mycenaean Greeks. The descendants of the people who wrote the Linear A tablets were part of the Sea Peoples” (Rendsburg 1996, 39). Within this diaspora, we find as many as six tribes mentioned by the Egyptians with ethnonyms that could be Semitic in origin.^{39,40} The most controversial among them may be the Ekwesh, who have been equated with the Achaeans, or the A-KA-WI-JA-DE (Kopanijs 2017, 122). Immersed in Linear A/B and multiple Semitic dictionaries, I saw at once Hebrew *ʾāḥ* (אָח) from the reconstructed root **ʾ-h-w*.⁴¹

The Peleset who settled along the Levantine coast were likely one such hybrid population of Mycenaeans and Minoans (Hitchcock 2018). Of the cities they called their own, Gaza would be the most famous. Historically, the Philistines were regarded as Greek-speaking foreigners to these lands. Given what we know of Minoan, it is more than probable that a subset of them were Semitic speakers as well. Regardless of how or when they assimilated into the local tribes, we can be assured that they did, as the archaeological record does not support prolonged warfare between them and the nascent Israelites.⁴² We

³⁹Of the nine Sea Peoples groups named in the Egyptian records, from Merneptah's Great Karnak Inscription and Athribis Stela (c. 1207 BCE), the Medinet Habu texts of Ramesses III, and Papyrus Harris I, six yield Semitic etymologies at varying confidence levels: the Denyen from *√d-y-n* “to judge,” the Ekwesh from *√ʾ-h-w* “brother,” the Sikel/Shekelesh from *√š-q-y* + *ʾel* “El's cupbearer,” the Tursha from *√t-r-s* “shield,” the Peleset from *√p-l-š* + feminine *-t* “the breach,” and the Sherden from *√š-r-d* “to serve.” Four of the nine carry a terminal *-š* consistent with the Hurrian relational suffix *-šše*, suggesting that the Egyptian scribes received the ethnonyms through their intermediaries rather than from the peoples themselves.

⁴⁰Semitic ethnonyms do not require Levantine ancestry. Ancient DNA from 210 individuals, including 196 from 14 Phoenician-Punic sites, has shown that Punic populations derived primarily from Sicily and the Aegean, with smaller contributions from North Africa and the Levant (Ringbauer et al. 2025). Viking burial grounds tell a similar story, with individuals of diverse genetic ancestry far beyond Scandinavia interred in full Norse rite (Margaryan et al. 2020).

⁴¹A-KA-WI-JA-DE appears on a single Linear B tablet from Knossos (KN Cf 914), the only attestation of the word anywhere in the Mycenaean world (Georgakopoulos 2012, 147; LiBER, KN Cf 914). The *-DE* is the Mycenaean allative suffix “toward,” making A-KA-WI-JA itself a toponym. Were it Linear A, we would read *ʾa-ḥa-wi-ya*, where *-JA* functions as the gentilic suffix visible on SU-KI-RI-TE-I-JA “the Keretian” (HT Zb 158b, Hagia Triada). The closest cognate is Arabic *أُخُوَّة* *ʾuḥuwwa* “brotherhood,” from the reconstructed root *√ʾ-h-w*. Both supreme Achaean commanders, Odysseus and Agamemnon, are explicitly called Samothracian initiates (Scholia on Apollonius Rhodius 1.917–18). Moreover, the cult of Demeter *Ἀχαιία* in the Boeotian-Euboean corridor was said to be founded by Gephyraioi (Γεφυραῖοι, from *√g-p-r* “to cover, veil”), whom Herodotus identifies as Phoenicians and companions of Kadmos (Hdt. 5.57–61, cited in Astour 1965a, 216).

⁴²Maeir, the foremost Philistine archaeologist, observes: “One would expect that after more than a century of quite intensive excavations at many sites in Philistia, evidence of the weaponry related to the Philistine culture would have emerged” (Maeir 2018, 158). He concludes that “the biblical and contemporary image

have instead many allusions to them, be they David's royal guard, or the כַּפְתֹרִים *kaphthorim* that head the menorah (Gordon 1954, 131). Most overlooked of all may be the King Manasseh, the grandfather of Josiah, who sought to restore the worship of Asherah and re-establish the בָּמוֹת *bamot*.⁴³ During and after the Babylonian exile, Crete and its Philistines became scorned by the prophets (Zeph 2:5; Ezek 25:16; Jer 47:4). Centuries later, in the reign of the Emperor Hadrian, the Gazans minted coins to Meinos whose name and likeness otherwise appear only on a single coin from Knossos, c. 400 BCE (Farhi 2017).

If any one culture could call itself a direct successor to Minoan Crete, it would be the Iron Age Phoenicians. Next to the alphabet, their perfection of Tyrian purple dye always served as a sign of this inheritance. Archaeological evidence indicates that the harvesting of murex shells first originated among the Minoans of Crete and Kythera (Stieglitz 1994). Our English word for *purple* descends from this same trade and has been traced to the Linear B term *po-pu-ro2* at Knossos (KN L 758), the apparent ancestor of Greek πορφύρα (*porphýra*). We may venture to derive it from the reduplicated Semitic root √p-'r, "to beautify, to glorify," the same root that gives Hebrew תִּפְאֶרֶת *tip'eret* (Exod 28:2, 5), and by extension the Kabbalistic *sefirah* called "King."⁴⁴ In all likelihood, there existed an enclave of Semitic speakers who held out on Crete, fortified by its hills and mountains⁴⁵, until the dissolution of the Mycenaean order, at which point they signaled for the return of their cousins abroad.⁴⁶ The latest scholarship supports Phoenician contact and residence at Knossos, Eleutherna, and Kommos from the eleventh century BCE on, lining up well with the end of Mycenaean administration.⁴⁷ The Tekke bowl found at Knossos (c. 1100–900

of the Philistines as the mighty enemy of the early Israelites might very [well] be the result of ideological narratives" (163).

⁴³In the Esarhaddon Prism, Manasseh is recorded as *Me-na-si-i*, "king of Judah" (RINAP 4.1 v 55; Leichty 2011, 16); under Ashurbanipal, *Mi-in-si-e* (Streck, *Assurbanipal* 2:138, line 25). Akkadian employs both roots √m-n-s and √m-n-n, "to allot," leaving the Bible's scribal gloss—"God has made me forget" (*naššānī*, Gen 41:51)—somewhat inadequate. As to the charge that he "passed his son through the fire" (2 Kgs 21:6), Maimonides calls it "a trifling and a light thing," noting that midwives even in his own day swung newborns over incense (*Guide for the Perplexed* III:37; trans. Friedländer).

⁴⁴Reduplication occurs naturally across Semitic as a signifier of emphasis, as in Arabic *zilzāl* (زلزال) and *waswasa* (وسوسة), and the liturgical Hebrew *shalom shalom* (שָׁלוֹם שָׁלוֹם). Astour proposed **parpar*, √p-r-p-r 'to agitate, to boil' (Astour 1965b, 350; cf. Stieglitz 1994, 53). He was close; but as Mohammed Ghassen Nouira—the world's foremost practitioner of Tyrian purple extraction (Abidellaoui 2022)—informs me, boiling would merely introduce oxygen into the mixture, disrupting what was meant to be a slow-heat reduction of the dye.

⁴⁵During the COVID pandemic, I found myself hiking the Diktamos gorge of Crete alone. After slipping on a wet boulder, injuring myself, and walking back 2 miles to the entrance of the trail, I met a sun-kissed Cretan groundskeeper who quickly fetched a first aid kit, regarding me with subtle bemusement. When I asked him how to say "thank god" in the local dialect, he told me, "(Ef)karisto i Thea" (Χαρίστω ἡ Θεά). Upon hearing this, I wept.

⁴⁶Much has been said of the Eteocretan language over the decades (Gordon 1966a, 8–16, 29; Rendsburg 1996; Magnelli & Petrantonio 2016). Apart from one proven forgery, the evidence supports its usage as a Phoenician-Greek intermediary. We see favorable signs of linguistic continuity in the Palaikastro libation formula, where the sound changes that distinguish Phoenician from Hebrew can be gleaned as early as the Middle Minoan, e.g. WA-JA → WA-E, à la *bayt* → *bēt*.

⁴⁷Shaw (1989, 180–181) documents the Phoenician triple shrine (Temple B) built over Minoan predecessors at Kommos. Kourou and Karetsou (1998) analyze a reused Phoenician cippus and associated material at Knossos. Stampolidis (1990, 375–403) reports on the Geometric-Archaic cemetery at Eleutherna, whose Levantine imports speak to Mediterranean trade connections in western Crete from the ninth century onward. Muñoz Sogas (2022, 20, 80) dates the earliest Phoenician ceramic at Kommos to the late eleventh or early tenth century and concludes that "the Near East and Crete were constantly connected, probably without

BCE) bears the name *l'mn* (𐤋𐤍𐤏), which I read as “Minos the Strong,” given the locale and ancestry of said mythical king (Puech 1983).⁴⁸ But principally, it is the art of being a scribe, of being a Phoenician, that these maritime traders carried down from the Bronze Age and into the present (Rendsburg 2022).

§11. Semitic Classification

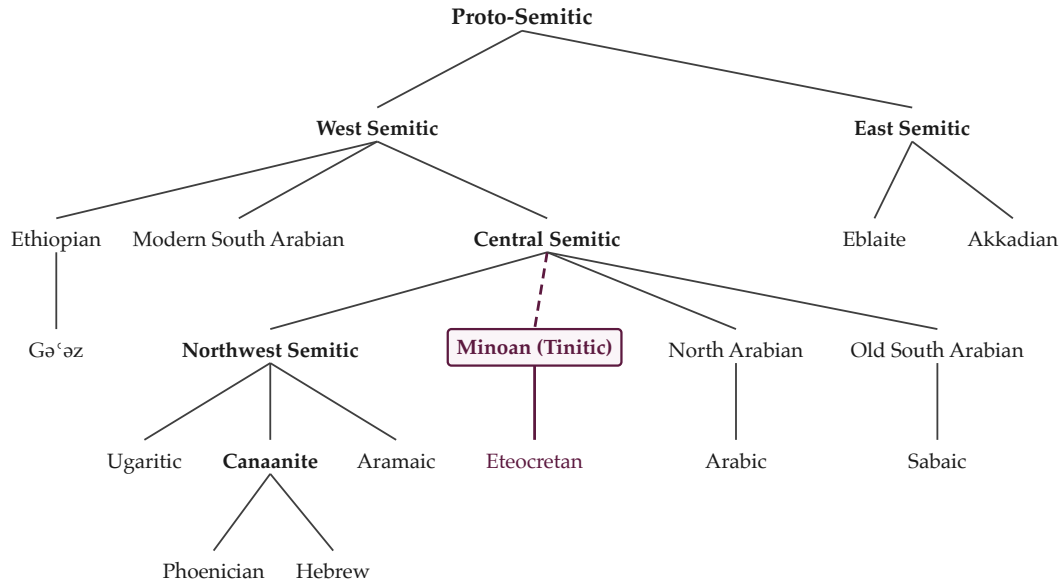


Figure 1: Semitic family tree, adapted from Huehnergard, *An Introduction to Ugaritic* (2012, 2), with Minoan (Tinitic) added within Central Semitic

Throughout this discourse, I have spoken conservatively of the Minoan language as Northwest Semitic. When we classify it as such, we remain in safe, albeit anachronistic territory. It must be emphasized that Crete, as an island characterized by gorges and mountain ranges, has always tended toward preservation. Aristotle, in discussing the hallowed antiquity of its constitutions, wrote: “It is saved by its locality; for distance has had the same effect as the expulsion of foreigners” (author’s translation; *Politics* II.10, 1272b17–18).⁴⁹ In his treatment of Greek dialects, Buck asserts that the Cretan of the

interruption, from 1200 BC onwards.”

⁴⁸Lipiński read “li Amon”; but no Phoenician stele has ever been found dedicated to the Egyptian deity (though there may be a single Neo-Punic formula, *l'dn l'mn*; KAI 118; Benz 1972, 270). We do find a multitude of verbal nominals in Hebrew and Punic, the most striking of which is “the strong one,” attested in *bdl'y*, *ʿbdl'y*, and *Ab-di-li-ʿti* (Puech 1983, 379–381). On a related note, a Carthaginian stele dedicated to Tanit and Baʿal-Hammon names a *bn mn*, “son of Mn” (CIS I, 774).

⁴⁹Ironically, Aristotle also compares Cretan laws to those of Carthage (*Politics* II.11, 1272b24), unaware of the cultural debt owed by the latter. He recognizes that Sparta borrowed the *syssitia* from Crete (II.10, 1272a), yet treats the Carthaginian parallels as independent convergence rather than shared inheritance.

Gortyna Code (c. 450 BCE) preserves an unmatched concentration of archaic features spanning phonology, morphology, syntax, and script which persisted into Roman times (Buck 1955, §273).⁵⁰ By these precedents, we may claim Minoan to be more archaic than its Northwest Semitic successors.⁵¹

Of the trove of Semitic terms encased in Linear A, the most compelling piece of evidence is in fact the first word we deciphered at Iouktas. What appeared a linguistic quirk, a tG stem operating outside the bounds of its root, may be a Proto-Semitic retention, as predicted by Huehnergard: “In the tG and tD stems, the *t* was probably prefixed to the base, thus tG *jV-t-C₁aC₂VC₃” (Huehnergard 2019, 65).⁵² Other peculiarities, like the mimation of JA-SA-SA-RA-ME, the energetic nun of the final √r-š-y verb, and the archaic *-tī person suffix (Pat-El 2025), suggest that Minoan held on to a number of its Mother’s features which had not yet distributed themselves among the East and West Semitic branches. Its core vowel set, /a, i, u/, which makes up 80.8% of the Linear A corpus’s vowel signs,⁵³ hints that the Canaanite Shift had not yet occurred, aligning with a Central Semitic language spoken by the first sailors of Tyre, Sidon, and the Nile Delta who landed, traded, and settled on the shores of Crete sometime in the 3rd millennium BCE.⁵⁴

In light of all these newfound discoveries, the old divisions must dissolve and die. The basin of the Mediterranean was the birthplace of countless traditions. No single one supersedes or invalidates the others, but enriches and broadens the plurality of beliefs and languages left to us by our ancestors. “Ya Diktu” slumbered for thirty-five hundred years, dormant on its mountaintop, to impress upon our minds this simple truth: what is gone is never truly lost. Be one secular or spiritual, they cannot deny the magic of resurrecting a prayer; of rekindling a power that had faded but never been extinguished

⁵⁰The Gortyna Code retains the digamma (φοῖνέος, “household member”) that Athens had dropped by the 8th century, and still writes in boustrophedon a full century after the rest of Greece had abandoned it (c. 550 BCE). Indeed, Buck explicitly traces Cretan forms to Proto-Indo-European reconstructions, e.g. ἐνρί “they are” ← *h₁sentī (cf. Skt. *santi*), -vri (3pl) ← *-nti, τίμι (dat.) ← *-smi (§§128, 138, 163).

⁵¹Knowing that the cult of the Minoan snake goddess was present on the island for 1,500 years, and that it “thrived with the move from the palace to the town sanctuary,” I am inclined to name the Proto-Central Semitic of Bronze Age Crete *Tinitic* (Gesell 2010, 139). The term potentially appears five times (once with its own *dubur*) and survives as the chief Goddess of the Carthaginians. Paula Gunn Allen tells us, “There is a spirit that pervades everything, that is capable of powerful song and radiant movement, and that moves in and out of the mind ... Old Spider Woman is one name for this quintessential spirit, and Serpent Woman is another” (Allen 1986, 13).

⁵²Mellison reconstructs a mixed Proto-Semitic system (infix Gt, prefixed tD), with system-wide prefixing in parts of NWS arising through paradigmatic leveling (2024, 713–715). If correctly parsed, Minoan’s prefixed tG at c. 1700 BCE would constitute early evidence of a comparable process. Remarkably, Keftiu Spell no. 32 in the London Medical Papyrus may provide a cross-script comparandum: under my proposed reading, it contains prefixed tG forms. See Appendix C for a brief introduction and translations of two Keftiu incantations.

⁵³My calculation is based on a corpus of approximately 1,780 Linear A inscriptions. Counting recognized syllabogram tokens, and excluding logograms, quantities, dividers, unknown signs, damaged tokens, and compounds, /a, i, u/ account for 3,823 of 4,733 tokens (80.8%). Olivier reaches the same verdict from the Linear B side: “clearly the vowel o, although not absent from ‘Minoan’, was nevertheless rare there” (Olivier 2024, 72).

⁵⁴Aubert (2020, 14–30) establishes Early Bronze Age Tyre as a maritime hub with interregional contacts. Colburn (2008, 203–206) catalogs the Eastern imports—ivory, gold, Egyptian scarabs, Near Eastern seals—that first appear on Crete in the EM II period (c. 2700–2200 BCE). Gordon (1966a, 43) argues for an initial wave of Semitic-speaking settlers reaching Crete in the early second millennium.

from this world. Within Linear A, there are melodies teeming with wisdom, remnants of people attuned to the passage of time, and the movement of our Earth. When we sing and listen for their whisper, they implore us to loosen our notions of race and tribe, as we concede that a holy tongue, a *lashon ha-qodesh*, is the birthright of every people—a *canCIÓN añeja* which will ferry us into ages untold.⁵⁵

Dedicated to Cyrus H. Gordon, Peter Gruen, Gary Rendsburg, and all the giants and mentors who paved this path on which I walk.

⁵⁵ Given its Punic roots, the ballads of Federico García Lorca have always conjured up for me the majesty of the mythical Golden Age, particularly “La Balada de la Placeta.”

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Appendix A: Translated Inscriptions

KNZc7 (Knossos, stone bowl, inked)

Unicode	Transliteration	Phonetic	Gloss	Confidence
𐀓 𐀓 𐀓	A-KA-NU	<i>ʾagānu</i>	“bowl” (Hebrew / Aramaic <i>ʾaggān</i> , Gordon 1966a, 27)	CONFIRMED
𐀓 𐀓	ZA-TI	<i>dāti</i>	“of” (fs gen. relative <i>d-</i> < PS <i>t-</i>)	PROBABLE
𐀓 𐀓 𐀓	DU-RA-RE	<i>durar</i>	“freedom, purity” (√d-r-r)	PROBABLE
𐀓 𐀓 𐀓	A-*79-RA	<i>ʾAṭirat</i>	“Athirat” (the Goddess)	CANDIDATE
𐀓 𐀓 𐀓	JA-SA-RA	<i>yašara</i>	“righteous” (√y-š-r)	PROBABLE
𐀓 𐀓 𐀓	A-NA-NE	<i>hanān</i>	“grace” (√h-n-n)	CANDIDATE
𐀓 𐀓	WI-PI	<i>wipī</i>	“and my mouth” (<i>wa-</i> + <i>pī</i>)	SPECULATIVE

“Bowl of purity — O Athirat! — (with) righteous grace, and my mouth.”

AB79 (𐀓) attestations. The sign appears in 25 distinct Linear A word-forms, but only seven Linear B attestations distributed across four forms. I propose that its Linear A value was /t/, here transliterated TH, in readings such as *79-DU (*tudu* “breast,” HT 51b and HT 99b), MA-*79 (*maṭu*, “man,” HT102), and *79-RI-NI-MA (*Tawrinima*, a “bull” name KNZb52). Ventris and Chadwick tentatively read *79 as zu?, whereas Melena defended *wo₂*, interpreting the four forms as a-wo₂, di-wo₂-nu, e-wi-su-wo₂-ko, and ma-wo₂. His argument rests on the possible alternation of e-wi-su-*79-ko / e-wi-su-zo-ko, although the identity of these two terms remains disputed (Judson 2020, 145–148; Killen 2024, 910–11). If they are variants, this points toward a z-like Mycenaean realization; it does not confirm *zo₂*, which Melena considers structurally ill-suited to the syllabary (Melena 2000, §15). I therefore regard Linear B evidence as compatible with a Greek adaptation of inherited Minoan /t/, rather than as proof of its Linear A value.

Appendix B: Index of Linear A Sign-Groups Cited in Davis 2026

The list below corresponds to the 66 sign-groups in Davis’s appendix (2026, 58–60) and one word in his body, with signs transliterated using Linear B homomorph values. Each entry is accompanied by its inscription reference, *GORILA* citation, SigLA link where available, and the closest Hebrew, Semitic, or contact-language comparandum (*cf.*).

A-DI-KI-TE-TE: **PK Za 11** (*GORILA* 4, 32–4). *Cf.* *Diqqite* “Diktu” (√d-q-q, Ugaritic *dqt* “female head of small cattle”); -TE-TE writes interdental /t/ by doubling convention (*cf.* SA-SA = /š/). PK dialectal isogloss of JA-DI-KI-TU.

- A-DU-RE-ZA: **KH 11.1** (GORILA 3, 38–39; SigLA). Mis-transcribed by Davis: the tablet reads A-DU · ZA, with a word divider; RE is absent. A-DU-RE-ZA is not an attested word.
- A-DU-KU-MI-NA: **ZA 10a.3–4** (GORILA 3, 168–71; SigLA). Unknown; cf. Ugaritic *Tukamuna* (t_kmn).
- A-JA: **SY Za 2** (GORILA 5, 64–5). Not in Davis’s appendix; cited in his body text formula table. Cf. Heb. חַי *hay* “alive,” יְחִי הַמֶּלֶךְ “long live the king!” (1 Sam 10:24); Ar. حَيَّة *hayyah* “serpent”; Heb. חַוְוָה *Hawwāh* “Eve” (Gen 3:20). Compare JA-JA /hayyā/ at PK Za 18 and SY Za 8 (√h-y-y).
- A-KU-MI-NA: **ZA 10a.1–2** (GORILA 3, 168–71; SigLA). Unknown; apparently related to the preceding form, though the exact morphology remains unresolved.
- A-MI-DA-O: **PH(?) 31b.5** (GORILA 1, 318–19). Cf. Amorite PN type ‘Ammī-DN “My kinsman (knows)”; Šamšī-da‘i (Gelb AS 21, no. 6272), ‘Ammī-šaduqa (OB king, Gelb AS 21); Heb. עַמִּישָׁדַי *‘Ammišadday* (Num 1:12). Vowel variant of A-MI-DA-U (√‘-m-m + √y-d-‘).
- A-MI-DA-U: **ZA 10a.3** (GORILA 3, 168–71; SigLA). Cf. Amorite PN type “My kinsman knows” (Gelb AS 21). Vowel variant of A-MI-DA-O (√‘-m-m + √y-d-‘).
- A-NA-NU-SI-JA-SE: **HT Zb 159** (GORILA 4, 66; SigLA). Cf. base A-NA-NU (PN ‘Anānu, √‘-n-n) + -SI-JA-SE, the vessel-label adjectival formation (as on KI-TA-NA-SI-JA-SE, PE Zb 3). Alt.: ‘Anānu šī-yāšē “‘Anānu(s)—which goes out” (disbursement clause).
- A-NA-TI-301-WA-JA: **IO Za 8** (GORILA 5, 30–1). Fragmentary single-word inscription (broken edges both sides). ‘Anati nawayā (divine name Anat + nominal nawayā “dwelling”).
- A-PA-RA-NE: **HT 96a.1** (GORILA 1, 156–57; SigLA). Cf. Heb. עִבְרָנִי *‘ibrānī* “Hebrew,” from √‘-b-r “to cross”; hence, “the crosser.”
- A-RA-TU: **ZA 7.1–2** (GORILA 3, 160–3; SigLA). Cf. Ug. ‘arṣ “earth,” Heb. אֶרֶץ *‘ereṣ* (√‘-r-ṣ).
- A-RA-TU-ME: **HT Wc 3024** (Hallager 1996, 34). Cf. Akk. *eršetum* “earth” (fem. + mimation; √‘-r-ṣ).
- A-RI-NI-TA: **HT 25a.3** (GORILA 1, 44–5; SigLA). Cf. Heb. אֶרֶץ *‘arī* “lion” (Gen 49:9); Ug. *ary* (KTU 1.5). PN paradigm with I-ZU-RI-NI-TA: “She-of-the-Lion” (√‘-r-y + -nīt).
- A-SA-SA-RA-ME: **IO Zb 10** (GORILA 5, 34), **PK Za 11a–b** (GORILA 4, 32–4). Davis’s PR Za 1c is a restoration (*802 for RA). Palaikastro prefix variant of JA-SA-SA-RA-ME (‘a-for ya-); Heb. יָאֵשָׁר *yāšār* + adverbial -am (√y-š-r “be upright”).
- A-SI-KI-RA: **KH 20.2** (GORILA 3, 52–3; SigLA). Cf. Heb. שֶׁכָּר *šēkār* “strong drink” + prosthetic A- (√š-k-r).
- A-TA-I-301-DE-KA: **ZA Zb 3.2** (GORILA 4, 112–13). If *301 = /na/, cf. tG √‘-n-y “who answered for you”; Heb. אָנָּה *‘ānāh*, Ug. ‘ny; -DE-KA = *dī-kā* “for you” (relative *dī* + 2ms -*kā*).
- A-TA-I-301-WA-E: **PK Za 11a** (GORILA 4, 32–4). Cf. tG √n-w-y “dwell” (same paradigm as A-TA-I-301-WA-JA).
- A-TA-I-301-WA-JA: **IO Za 2.1** (GORILA 5, 18–9). Cf. tG √n-w-y “I make myself a dwelling”; t-stem shape as in Heb. *hitnabbē’* (√n-b-‘, 1 Sam 10:6).

- A-TA-NA-TE: **ZA 10a.2** (GORILA 3, 168–71; SigLA). Variant of A-TA-NA (ZA 9) with feminine -at- written -TE (final vowel dead; $\sqrt{y-t-n}$ “to give”).
- DA-I-PI-TA: **ZA 10a.4–5** (GORILA 3, 168–71; SigLA). Cf. LB *da-i-pi-ta* (KN Bk 799); pre-Greek, non-Semitic substrate PN attested in both scripts.
- DA-KU-SE-NE: **HT 103.4–5** (GORILA 1, 170–71; SigLA). Cf. Hurrian *Daku-šenni* (Nuzi/Ugarit); Hurr. *tak-* “to love” + *-šenni* “brother”—“beloved brother.”
- DA-KU-SE-NE-TI: **HT 104.1–2** (GORILA 1, 170–71; SigLA). Cf. Hurrian *Daku-šenni* (bare $2\times$ on HT 103) + -TI, the ending on every entry of the HT 104 roster (DA-KU-SE-NE-TI, I-DU-TI, PA-DA-SU-TI, summed by KU-RO 95).
- DA-MA-TE: **KY Za 2** (Sakellarakis and Olivier 1994). Cf. Ug. *dmt* “tower” (DULAT 272), *dmt-qdš* “Tower of Holiness”; Akk. *dimtu* “tower-house” ($\sqrt{d-m-t}$).
- DU-RE-ZA-SE: **ZA 10a.5** (GORILA 3, 168–71; SigLA). Cf. DU-RE-ZA at Khania and Proto-Semitic terminative *-sa:* perhaps “toward Dureza” (Butts 2022, 539–58).
- I-DA-MA-TE: **AR Zf 1–2** (GORILA 4, 142, 162). Prothetic I- before DA-MA-TE (“the tower”; cf. KY Za 2).
- I-KU-PA₃-NA-TU-NA-TE: **AP Za 2.1** (GORILA 4, 4–5). Cf. Hurr./Anat. *Kubaba*: I-locative + *kubānātu* (the HT 47a/119 theophoric) + -NA-TE—either Sem. *-na* “our” + enclitic locative *-te*, or Hurr. *=na* (pl. article) + *=ta/te* (directive), “at/to the (our) Kubaba-attendants.”
- I-NA-JA-PA-QA: **PK Za 11d** (GORILA 4, 32–4). Cf. Ar. *’inna* “behold” ($\sqrt{’-n-n}$) + Heb. פָּקַח *pāqah* “open (eyes)” (Isa 42:7); *h* drops ($\sqrt{’-n-n} + \sqrt{p-q-h}$).
- I-NA-JA-RE-TA: **AP Za 2.2** (GORILA 4, 4–5). Cf. *’ina yir’āta* “in reverence” ($\sqrt{y-r-’}$; Heb. יִירָא *yir’āh* “awe, reverence”).
- I-PI-NA-MA: **IO Za 2.1** (GORILA 5, 18–9). Cf. Heb. פָּנִים *pānīm* “presence/face” ($\sqrt{p-n-y}$).
- I-PI-NA-MI-NA: **PK Za 10** (GORILA 4, 29–31). Cf. Heb. פָּנִים *pānīm* “presence”; expanded form of I-PI-NA-MA ($\sqrt{p-n-y}$ “face/presence”). The final -NA invites comparison with Huehnergard’s reconstructed Proto-Semitic nonbound plural allomorph **-na* after long vowels (2019, 59–61).
- I-TI-TI-KU-NI: **HT 96a.1** (GORILA 1, 156–57; SigLA). Cf. Ug. $\sqrt{ntk}$ “pour out” + energetic *-ni* (cf. Amarna *-ni*, Heb. paragogic nun Job 19:2).
- I-ZU-RI-NI-TA: **PH 6.2** (GORILA 1, 292–93; SigLA). Cf. PS **tawr-* “bull”; Ug. *tr*; Heb. שׁוֹר *šōr*. Fem. of ZU-RI-NI-MA ($\sqrt{t-w-r}$ “bull” + *-nīt*).
- JA-DI-KI-TE-TE: **PK Za 15** (GORILA 4, 41). Cf. *yā Diqqite* “O Dikte!” (vocative); -TE-TE = /t/ by doubling convention. Same paradigm as JA-DI-KI-TU and A-DI-KI-TE-TE ($\sqrt{d-q-q}$).
- JA-DI-KI-TU: **IO Za 2.1** (GORILA 5, 18–9). Cf. Heb. *yā Diqtu* “O Dikte!” (vocative; toponym Dikte / $\sqrt{d-q-q}$).
- JA-SA-SA-RA-MA-NA: **KN Za 10** (GORILA 4, 8–9). Cf. Heb. יָשָׁר *yāšār* “upright” + מָנָה *mānāh* “to allot” ($\sqrt{y-š-r} + \sqrt{m-n-y}$).
- JA-SA-SA-RA-ME: **PS Za 2.2** (GORILA 4, 52–5; SigLA). Cf. Heb. יָשָׁר *yāšār* “upright” + adverbial *-am* ($\sqrt{y-š-r}$).
- JA-SU-MA-TU: **SY Za 2a** (GORILA 5, 64–5). Cf. Heb. שָׁמַט *šāmaṭ* “release” ($\sqrt{š-m-t}$).

- JA-TA-I-^{*}301-U-JA: **AP Za 1** (GORILA 4, 2–3). Cf. tG $\sqrt{n-w-y}$ (3ms prefix *ya-*; same paradigm as A-TA-I-^{*}301-WA-JA).
- KI-DA-RO: **HT 117a.9** (GORILA 1, 196–99; SigLA). Cf. Heb. קְדֵרָה *qadērāh* “pot” ($\sqrt{q-d-r}$ “earthenware”); Akk. *diqāru* “bowl” is the metathetic variant ($q-d-r \sim d-q-r$).
- KI-TA-NA-SI-JA-SE: **PE Zb 3** (Tsipopoulou and Hallager 1996, 31, 34–6). Cf. $\sqrt{k-t-n}$ “linen”: *kitāna* (Ug. *ktn*, Akk. *kitû*, Aram. *kittānā*; Heb. כִּתּוֹנָה *kuttōnet* the garment derivative; χιτών via LB *ki-to*) + -SI-JA-SE, the vessel-label adjectival formation—“of linen, linen-ware”. Alt.: *kitāna šī-yāšē* “linen which goes out” (disbursement clause).
- KU-MI-NA-QE: **HT Wc 3014a–b** (GORILA 2, 76; SigLA). Cf. Heb. כַּמּוֹן *kamōn*, Akk. *kamūnu*, LB *ku-mi-no* ($\sqrt{k-m-n}$ “cumin”). KU-MI-NA occupies side a; QE appears on side b before the CAP logogram and is likely from $\sqrt{q-b-b}$, cf. Heb. קָב *qab*.
- KU-PA₃-NA-TU: **HT 47a.1–2** (GORILA 1, 90–1; SigLA), **HT 119**. Cf. Hurr./Anat. *Kubaba* + -ānu + -atu (feminine of KU-PA₃-NU).
- KU-PA₃-NU: **HT 1.3–4** (GORILA 1, 2–3; SigLA). Cf. Hurr./Anat. *Kubaba* + -ānu; rival Ug. *Gupanu* ($\sqrt{g-p-n}$). Seven tablets (HT 1, 3, 49a, 88, 117a, 122a, PH(?) 31a); on HT 88 it stands in one six-name roster with KU-PA₃-PA₃ (*Kubaba* herself).
- MA-KA-I-SE: **ZA 8.4** (GORILA 3, 164–65; SigLA). Cf. PS ^{*}mak(i)s- “customs official”; Heb. מֵקֶס *mekes* (Num 31:28); Akk. *miksu* ($\sqrt{m-k-s}$, *maqtil* pattern).
- MA-KA-I-TA: **ZA 5b.2–3** (GORILA 3, 152–55; SigLA). Cf. Eg. *mk.t* “protection” (Egyptian contact).
- NA-MA-MA-TI-TI-^{*}319: **HT Zd 155** (GORILA 4, 130–31; SigLA). Cf. Heb. נְעֻמָּת *na‘āmāt* “Naamath” ($\sqrt{n-‘-m}$ “pleasant”); TI-TI writes /t/ by doubling convention (cf. TE-TE = /t/ on A-DI-KI-TE-TE). If ^{*}319 = /hū/: *na‘māt-hū* “his pleasant one” (fem. + 3ms possessive).
- PA-JA-RE: **ZA 10b.5–6** (GORILA 3, 168–71; SigLA). Cf. Eg. *p3-y-R* “He-of-Re” (Egyptian theophoric PN).
- PA-RA-NE: **HT 115a.4** (GORILA 1, 188–91; SigLA). Cf. A-PA-RA-NE above; shortened form.
- RI-RU-MA: **HT 118.4** (GORILA 1, 200–1; SigLA). Cf. Eg. *rrj* “pig” + mimation (Egyptian contact).
- RI-RU-MA-TI: **PH(?) 31b.4** (GORILA 1, 318–19). No viable reading.
- RU-MA-TA: **HT 29.1** (GORILA 1, 54–5; SigLA). Cf. Heb. רָמָה *rāmāh* “height” ($\sqrt{r-w-m}$ “be high”).
- RU-MA-TA-SE: **ZA 20.3** (GORILA 3, 192–93; SigLA). Cf. Heb. רָמָה *rāmāh* + gentilic -SE ($\sqrt{r-w-m}$).
- SI-KI-RA: **HT 8a.4** (GORILA 1, 16–7; SigLA). Cf. Heb. שֶׁכָּר *šēkār*, Akk. *šikaru* “beer” ($\sqrt{š-k-r}$).
- SU-KI-RI-TA: **PH Wa 32** (GORILA 2, 90; SigLA). Cf. LB *su-ki-ri-to* (KN As(2) 1516); toponym Sybrita (cross-script continuity).
- SU-KI-RI-TE-I-JA: **HT Zb 158** (GORILA 4, 64–5; SigLA). Cf. SU-KI-RI-TA + gentilic adjective -TE-I-JA (toponym + gentilic).
- TA-NA-I-^{*}301-TI: **PS Za 2.2** (GORILA 4, 52–5; SigLA). Cf. $\sqrt{‘-n-y}$ “answer”: proposed N-stem 2fs prefix-conjugation, “may you answer,” with final -TI interpreted as a t-based

second-person feminine marker.

TA-NA-I-***301**-U-TI-NU: **IO Za 6** (GORILA 5, 24–7). Cf. $\sqrt{\text{c}}$ -n-y “answer”: N-stem 3fs jussive + 2ps object + energetic -nū, “may she answer for you.” Suffix-variant counterpart of TA-NA-I-***301**-TI (PS Za 2) in the same formula slot.

TA-NA-TE: **ZA 10a.1** (GORILA 3, 168–71; SigLA). Cf. LB ta-na-to (KN De 1618); possibly related to A-TA-NA-TE (theophoric PN, $\sqrt{\text{y}}$ -t-n) or independently $\sqrt{\text{t}}$ -n-n (Tanit).

TI-TI-KU: **HT 35.1** (GORILA 1, 66–7; SigLA). Cf. Heb. הִתִּיכּוּ *hittikū* “they disbursed” (2 Kgs 22:9); Ug. $\sqrt{\text{ntk}}$ (KTU 1.14). Nun→geminate /tt/ ($\sqrt{\text{n}}$ -t-k “pour out”).

U-NA-KA-NA-SI: **KO Za 1c** (GORILA 4, 18–20). *hunna kanasī*, “behold, my assembly!”: presentative *hunna* + $\sqrt{\text{k}}$ -n-s + 1cs -ī (Heb. כָּאֵס *kānas* “gather,” כְּנֶסֶת *kāneset* “assembly”).

U-NA-RU-KA-JA-SI: **PK Za 12c** (GORILA 4, 35–8). Davis prints U-NA-RU-KA-NA-JA-SI, but the published transcription reads U-NA-RU-KA-JA-SI amid damage. Cf. U-NA-RU-KA-NA-SI (IO Za 16) and U-NA-RU-KA-NA-TI (PK Za 11).

U-NA-RU-KA-NA-TI: **PK Za 11b** (GORILA 4, 32–4). Cf. *hunna lu kanasiti*; coda /s/ unwritten, per the Linear B rule that drops syllable-final *s* before a stop (Ventris and Chadwick 1956, 45; cf. *pa-ka-na* = *phasgana*).

U-TA-I-SE: **KH 7b.2** (GORILA 3, 28–31; SigLA). Perhaps an onomastic form based on Amorite *’ūta’/jūta’* “he found” ($\sqrt{\text{w}}$ -t-’; Gelb 1980), with final -SE.

WI-JA-SU-MA-TI-TI-***319**: **HT Zd 157+156** (GORILA 4, 132–35). Cf. Heb. שָׁמַטְךָ *šāmaṭ* “release” ($\sqrt{\text{š}}$ -m-ṭ); TI-TI = /t/ by doubling convention. If ***319** = /hū/: *šāmāṭ-hū* “his release” (fem. + 3ms possessive; Ug. -*hu*, Tropper UG §41.221.51).

ZU-RI-NI-MA: **KN Zb 52** (Macdonald 2000, 64, fig. 39). Cf. Ug. *tr* “bull”; masc. counterpart of I-ZU-RI-NI-TA + mimation ($\sqrt{\text{t}}$ -w-r “bull”).

***312**-TA: **HT 10b.2** (GORILA 1, 22–3; SigLA). Cf. ***312** = KITNU (logogram); Heb. כֻּתְּנוֹת *kuttōnet* “tunic, garment” ($\sqrt{\text{k}}$ -t-n). The root is spelled out syllabically at PE Zb 3 (KI-TA-NA-SI-JA-SE).

***312**-TE-TE: **HT 26a.1** (GORILA 1, 46–7; SigLA). Cf. Ug. *ktn* “tunic, cloth item”; Heb. כֻּתְּנוֹת *kuttōnet* “tunic.” If ***312** = KITNU (logogram), TE-TE may represent /t/ by doubling convention, yielding *kitnūt*, perhaps a linen or finished textile item.

Appendix C: Keftiu Incantations from the London Medical Papyrus

The London Medical Papyrus (BM 10059, fourteenth century BCE) contains seven foreign spells, two of which (nos. 32–33) are in the “Keftiu language” and prove to be the fullest Bronze Age record of Minoan outside the Aegean scripts. Steiner (1992) demonstrated that six of these spells (#27–31, #33) are Northwest Semitic, interpreting them through a Phoenician-Aramaic prism. He omitted Spell #32, dismissing it as “non-Semitic” (Steiner 1992, 197) and citing Bossert’s 1931 German treatment.

The five-word incantation was recorded in Egyptian group-writing, a syllabic orthography reserved for foreign words that preserves phonological distinctions—pharyngeal ʿayin , a three-way sibilant split, the liquid merger of /l/ and /r/—which the Linear A syllabary collapses. Kyriakidis (2002a) provides the sharper phonological map of the group-writing signs; Akulov (2021; 2023), working from the Hattic hypothesis, parsed the signs

nearly identically. Reconciling the two, and interpreting them as I would Linear A, I arrived at the following readings, encouraged by a Biblical Psalm:

Spell #32: Against Asiatic Disease (LMP 11,4–7)

The Egyptian frame reads: “Spell for the Asiatic Disease in Keftiw language” (Wreszinski 1912, 151; Kyriakidis 2002a, 213).

#	Group Writing	Semitic Reading	Gloss	Det.
1	s3n	<i>šēn</i>	“tooth of—” (construct, √š-n-n, cf. 1 Sam 14:4)	plurality
2	tik3pwp	<i>ti-kappup</i>	“(that) curves itself” (tG-stem √k-p-p, cf. Mic 6:6 יִכְּפֹּף)	duality
3	w33yw3ti	<i>wa-yšū ‘ātī</i>	“and my salvation!” (fs constr. √y-š- ^c + 1cs gen.)	speak
4	ym‘n	<i>yamīn</i>	“right hand” (√y-m-n)	plurality
5	tiirk3k3	<i>tirqaqī</i>	“spit out!” (tG √r-q-q)	speak

Translation: “O tooth that curves itself—my salvation!—right hand, spit out (the disease)!”

Psalm 60:7: הוֹשִׁיעָה יְמִינָה *hōšī‘ā yəminəkā* “Save with your right hand!”

What arrests the reader first is the construct chain, *šēn ti-kappup*, or literally “the tooth that curves itself.” We follow it to the pairing of √y-š-^c “to save” alongside √y-m-n “right hand,” in the style of Psalm 60:7. The group-writing supports this pairing, since Kyriakidis transcribes the fourth word as *j(a,u)-mV-n* (the group *m^c* writing /ma/), compatible with Semitic *yamīn*; Akulov instead reads Hattic *imallen*. Whether word 3 contains a yod (Kyriakidis) or an ayin (Akulov) is the decisive phonological question; if yod, *wa-yšū ‘ātī* parses as the conjunction *wa-* plus the feminine noun הוֹשִׁיעָה *yšū ‘ā* “salvation” in construct (*-ātī*) with the 1cs genitive *-ī*—standard NWS morphology attested in archaic poetry (Isa 51:6 וְיִשְׁעָתִי “and my salvation”; Job 30:15 וְיִשְׁעָתִי; cf. Exod 15:2). The tG-stem prefix on *tirqaqī* mirrors A-TA-I-301-WA-JA exactly: reflexive *t-*, prefixed rather than infixed, albeit in the 2fs rather than the 1cs.

Spell #33: Against Samānu Disease (LMP 11,8–12)

Haider (2001, 480–481) identified deity names in the second Keftiu spell. Steiner reads √y-š-^c “go out” and *hanqatu* “strangling-demon” (√ḥ-n-q, cf. Nahum 2:13) in his own analysis, leaving the rubric’s final two units unread (Akulov 2023, 3–4). Applying our model to the full transcription:

#	Group Writing	Semitic Reading	Gloss	Det.
R1	wbqy	<i>wa-b(u)haqī</i>	“and the <i>bahaq-rash</i> ” (√b-h-q, cf. Lev 13:39 בַּהֶק)	disease
R2	s3t	<i>šē’et</i>	“the <i>šē’et</i> -mark” (√n-š-’, cf. Lev 13:2 נֶשֶׁא; or Eg. <i>s3tw</i> “soil”)	t (phonetic)
1	s3bw	<i>sabbū</i>	“turn away!” (2mp imper. √s-b-b, cf. Ps 48:13 סִבּוּ)	motion
2	y3yd33	<i>yaš’a</i>	“go out!” (3ms volitive <i>yaqtula</i> √y-š-’; Moran 1960)	motion
3	hwnm‘k3tw	<i>hanqatu</i>	“O strangling-demon!” (vocative √h-n-q)	speak
4	rp33y	<i>rp’ī</i>	“my Healer!” (deity, √r-p-’ + 1cs poss.)	god
5	p33wry	<i>pa’ūrī</i>	“I cry out!” (verbal noun √p-‘-r “open the mouth” + 1cs poss.)	speak
6	m’y3	<i>Mayyā</i>	“O Mayyā!” (deity: deified Water)	god

Translation: “Turn away! Go out, strangling-demon! My Healer—I cry out to Mayyā!”

A classic ANE incantation: command the disease to depart, name the demon, and invoke protective spirits. The deity *rp’ī* maps to Ugaritic *Rap’u* “the Healer,” the epithet we discussed in connection with Eshmun, patron of the Rephaim (KTU 1.108:1: *rp’u mlk ‘lm*, “the Healer, King of Eternity”; author’s translation; Copenhagen Ugaritic Corpus v0.2.7) and the theophoric name Raphael (רַפָּאֵל). The second deity, *Mayyā*, matches Aramaic *mayyā* “water,” from the Semitic etymon *ma’* (*mayim*, *mû*, *mā’*) and is invoked for purification alongside the Healer, consistent with the Egyptian instructions to recite the spell “over froth of a fermented drink, urine, and *sḏ.t*” (Kyriakidis 2002a, 213). If our readings of Spells #32 and 33 hold, all seven foreign spells in the London Medical Papyrus are Semitic.